



PM MODI DEVOTING PERSONAL ATTENTION TO DEVELOPING RUSSIAN-INDIAN RELATIONS, SAYS PUTIN

## Jaishankar meets Putin, focus on trade, energy, fertilisers, high-tech

Modi and Putin to meet twice in next few weeks for SCO, BRICS

Shubhajit Roy  
New Delhi, August 24

AHEAD OF two scheduled meetings between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Russian President Vladimir Putin in the next three weeks, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar called on the latter in Moscow on Monday. Putin told Jaishankar that among the areas of bilateral cooperation with India, Russia is giving priority to energy, fertilisers, nuclear energy and high technology sectors.



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar with Russian President Vladimir Putin in Moscow on Monday. AP

Modi and Putin are expected to meet at the SCO (Shanghai Cooperation Organisation) summit in Kyrgyzstan on August 31-September 1, and

again at the BRICS summit in New Delhi on September 12-13. Underlining the increase in bilateral trade between the two

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## Govt on Gor's remarks: Trump unpredictable, so took cautious approach

Express News Service  
New Delhi, August 24

CITING US President Donald Trump's "unpredictable behaviour" when meeting foreign leaders, government sources on Monday said India, therefore, adopted a "cautious approach" when Prime Minister Narendra Modi met him in France in June this year.

The clarification came in response to US Ambassador Sergio Gor's public remarks that the Indian side had asked the

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TRUMP MOVES TO HIKE H-1B VISA FEE TO OVER \$100,000

NEW U.S. SANCTIONS 'AIM TO BLOCK IRAN REVENUE SOURCES'

US administration to "not do a full press conference, no questions" after the meeting

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## OBC creamy layer candidates in '25 civil services exam: Govt seeks SC directions

Shyam Lal Yadav  
New Delhi, August 24

THE CENTRE on Monday sought "clarifications and appropriate directions" from the Supreme Court on the applicability of its March 11 judgment ordering the consideration of claims by nearly 100 OBC candidates who were selected in Civil Services Examinations (CSE) since 2016 but rejected by the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) on the basis of creamy layer criteria.

The Centre's clarification plea comes just ahead of the start of the Foundation Course for the CSE-2025 batch, tentatively scheduled to begin at the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration in Mussoorie this week.

The appeal, the Centre emphasised, was concerned solely with CSE-2025, whose selection process "stood substantially concluded prior to the pronouncement of the judgment and is presently at the terminal stage of service allocation".

In its appeal, the DoPT, however, does not mention the applicability of the Supreme Court judgment from next batches.

E. EXPLAINED

### Govt says will have cascading effect

The Centre has argued that SC's March 11 judgment came five days after the final result of CSE-2025 was declared. Delay in finalisation of the category-wise merit and allocation list would have a cascading effect — from training to seniority and pay fixation of the incoming batch.

The Centre said that the March 11 judgment "altering settled position (on creamy layer) was rendered five days after the final result of CSE-2025 already stood declared". Any delay in finalisation of the category-wise merit and allocation list would have a cascading effect on the training schedule, batch strength, logistics arrangements, the training calendar fixed by the respective academies, cadre allocation for IAS and IPS officers, and the seniority and pay fixation of the batches.

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### EXPRESS special

FORM WITH WORSHIPPERS' AADHAAR OR PAN

## Tough conversion law kicks in this week, Mumbai pastors ask churchgoers to sign form they are praying of their 'free will'

'Self-declaration' more as assurance, say pastors in Vasai-Virar, Mira-Bhayandar, Thane, Mumbai, Palghar after incidents of disrupted Sunday prayers and FIRs

Purnima Sah  
Mumbai, Mira-Bhayandar, Vasai-Virar, Palghar, Thane, August 24

THE MAHARASHTRA anti-conversion law that toughens legal provisions against forced conversion comes into effect August 28. Its shadow has already fallen on Christian congregations across the Mumbai Metropolitan Region. At prayer halls in Vasai-Virar, Mira-Bhayandar and beyond, local pastors are asking worshippers to do something they never had to before — fill a form.

This "self-declaration" states that they are attending the prayer meeting of their own "choice" and face "no pressure, inducement, temptation, lure, or threat of any kind". It further says their decision to attend church "is completely personal, voluntary, and independent." The form asks for a passport-size photograph and an Aadhaar or PAN number.

Until this year, anyone could walk in.

Over the past month, *The Indian Express* found these forms being circulated — in English, Marathi and Hindi — to congregations in Mumbai, Mira-Bhayandar, Vasai-Virar, Palghar and Thane. This follows a run of Sunday disruptions at prayer meetings over the past five months: there



Worshippers sign the form at New Hope Church in Virar. PURNIMA SAH



### • THE 'DECLARATION'

- They attend church voluntarily.
- They participate in prayers of their own free will.
- Their participation is part of their religious freedom and a right guaranteed under Constitution of India.
- In case anyone makes a false allegation against them or the church, the voluntary application/self-declaration may be produced as legal evidence.

have been nine FIRs linked to five such disruptions between April and July.

### Pattern of prayer, protest

Typically, a prayer meeting is held on a Sunday, often in a

rented hall, school, banquet hall or home. People identifying themselves as Bajrang Dal or VHP workers object, often alleging that Hindus are being converted. Police are called, both sides are taken to the station,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

## J&K reopens probe into 1998 massacre of 23 Kashmiri Pandits

Bashaarat Masood  
Srinagar, August 24

JAMMU AND Kashmir's State Investigation Agency (SIA) has reopened the Wandhama massacre case, 28 years after militants gunned down 23 Kashmiri Pandits in Ganderbal district in the Valley.

Sources in the SIA said the case was reopened as part of the agency's efforts to reinvestigate the killings of Kashmiri Pandits and gather fresh evidence to identify those responsible.

"SIA Kashmir has already launched a focused investigation into these decades-old cases as a mission of utmost importance. All-out efforts are underway to unravel the underlying conspiracies, unearth and establish credible evidence, and identify the perpetrators strictly on the basis of evidence and witness testimony," said a senior SIA official. "The objective is clear: to bring these cases to their logical conclusion on merits, ensuring

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## Lessons from Jantar Mantar: Delhi Police chief orders intel revamp

Sakshi Chand  
New Delhi, August 24

DELHI POLICE Commissioner Anurag Kumar has asked the intelligence wing of the force to expand its information-gathering efforts, and to collect at least 10 specific pieces of intelligence ahead of every planned protest.

Sources said the directive was issued earlier this month after the protests at Jantar Mantar and Connaught Place in July saw a much bigger turnout than anticipated, "exposing gaps" in intelligence-collection.

Police were caught flatfooted

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

### • 10 SPECIFIC PIECES OF INTELLIGENCE

The intelligence wing has been directed to collect and analyse:

- Profile of participants
- State-wise participation
- Modes of mobilisation
- Names of leaders and key functionaries
- Agenda or demands of the protesters
- Places of stay and movement
- Local contacts and linkages



At least 50,000 protesters hit the streets in Delhi on July 20

- Organisational affiliations
- Sources of funding
- Logistical arrangements

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 25~08~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or

indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of

other topics in the main exam.



[ FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON [WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](http://WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM) ]

## Jaishankar meets Putin in Russia

sides, Putin credited Modi for giving “personal attention” to the relationship. “Your visit today underscores the level of relations that has long been established between Russia and India, over decades. We continue to work together in virtually all areas. This includes governmental ties, inter-parliamentary ties, and economic co-operation,” Putin told Jaishankar.

“I am pleased to note that our trade turnover has increased this year. While it declined slightly last year, it’s growing this year, and this is partly, and perhaps primarily, thanks to Prime Minister (Narendra Modi), who is devoting his personal attention to developing Russian-Indian relations,” he said.

Intensifying trade and economic relations has been identified as a priority area by both the leaders, who had set a bilateral trade target of US\$ 100 billion by 2030. Bilateral trade between the two sides touched a record high of US\$ 68.7 billion in FY 2024-25; it was US\$ 59.863 billion in FY 2025-26.

“At the beginning of our

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conversation, I would like to ask you to convey my best wishes to Modi. I hope to see him soon, as we planned, within the framework of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation very soon. Our schedule is such that we will probably be able to meet again this year,” Putin said.

Modi is expected to travel to Uzbekistan for a bilateral visit on August 29-30, and then to Kyrgyzstan for the SCO leaders’ summit on August 31-September 1.

Putin also gave a sense of the discussions held between Jaishankar and Russian First Deputy Prime Minister Denis Manturov under the Inter-Governmental Commission, noting that various issues including energy, fertiliser supplies, nuclear energy and high-technology cooperation were on the agenda.

“One of these issues is not only energy — it is, of course, fertiliser supplies. We are doing everything to address this issue for Indian farmers, for agriculture; we are increasing these supplies and are ready to do so further. And all other issues re-

lated to nuclear energy, cooperation in high-tech sectors, and other areas — they are all on the agenda, and... progressing quite steadily,” Putin said.

Jaishankar conveyed Modi’s wishes to Putin, and said he had sent a “personal communication”. “We had a meeting of the Inter-Governmental Commission. I think overall we have a good report to give to you. I think our economic cooperation, trade, energy, fertilisers, nuclear, and other dimensions as well — I’d be pleased to speak about them in detail. Overall, I think our economic cooperation has grown very significantly,” he said.

“Prime Minister Modi looks forward to meeting you at the SCO Summit, then welcoming you to India for the BRICS Summit, and, in due course, as per your mutual convenience, having the annual summit, so we have a very strong picture of co-operation to present,” Jaishankar said, addressing Putin.

India is set to host the BRICS leaders’ summit in New Delhi on September 12-13; Putin and Chinese President Xi Jinping

are among those expected to attend.

Jaishankar is on a two-day visit to Russia (August 23-24). Earlier in the day, he co-chaired the 27th session of the India-Russia Inter-Governmental Commission on Trade, Economic, Scientific, Technological and Cultural Cooperation (IRIGC-TEC) with Manturov.

While the Indian side included India’s Ambassador to Russia Vinay Kumar and Joint Secretary, Eurasia Division, Mayank Singh, the Russian side was represented by Manturov, Minister of Foreign Affairs Sergey Lavrov, Deputy Chief of Staff of the Presidential Executive Office Maksim Oreshkin, and Aide to the President of Russia Yury Ushakov.

The India-Russia Inter-Governmental Commission (IRIGC) has two divisions: the Trade, Economic, Scientific, Technological and Cultural Cooperation (IRIGC-TEC), co-chaired by Jaishankar and Manturov; and the Military and Military-Technical Cooperation (IRIGC-M&MTC), headed by the defence ministers of the two countries.

## Govt on Gor remarks

between the two leaders. Trump, however, disregarded this request and took questions from the media.

Facing criticism from the Opposition, government sources said: “Discussions regarding arrangements for public appearances of leaders are normal practice ahead of any VVIP visit. In this regard, the Indian side communicated its standard practice for such visits... Delegations when meeting the US President are wary about his unpredictable behaviour, as may be seen from his interactions with the President of South Africa, Ukraine etc. Thus, the cautious approach by India.”

At a televised meeting in February last year, Trump and Vice President J D Vance had engaged in a heated argument with Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy. In May last year, Trump also sought to corner South African President Cyril

Ramaphosa on the alleged discrimination against White farmers.

Modi has rarely addressed press conferences with foreign leaders — Trump and former British Prime Minister David Cameron are among the few exceptions. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) has re-branded the joint media interactions as “media appearances” and “media statements”.

This has not gone down well in the western media; in May this year, a Norwegian journalist questioned MEA officials on this during Modi’s visit to Oslo for the India-Nordic summit.

Speaking at the Economic Times World Leaders Forum on Saturday, US Ambassador Gor said, “The fact that our President and Prime Minister Modi have such a deep and personal friendship makes it a lot easier for me frankly. It is one of those things that you may have seen.

I travelled with President Trump to G7 two months ago in Evian and they brought in the cameras.”

He was referring to the meeting between Modi and Trump on June 17, on the sidelines of the G7 leaders summit — their first since Op Sindoor last year. The meeting was highly anticipated as there was frostiness in the ties after Trump’s claims that he had brokered the ceasefire between India and Pakistan.

“I will share it as an anecdote...we were behind the scenes, behind the stage, and at one point it was just the President and I. And he asked me what are the Indians going to raise. We went over some topics. And he said, did they have any asks. And MEA had one ask. And let’s bring in the media, let’s not do a full press conference, no questions. And so I told the President, Indians prefer no questions. So he said no problem. The meeting starts, the press comes in. There are 50 cameras. President sitting here,

Prime Minister sitting there. They both speak for a few minutes. As soon as they get done, the first thing the President does is, looks at the cameras and says any questions? And that opened everything up. And he did a 45-minute press conference, and everything was on the table,” Gor said at the event.

Raising Gor’s remarks, Congress leader Pawan Khara said in a post on X: “This @MEAIndia response to @USAmbIndia comment is revealing because: it suggests that it may be Modi’s normal practice to plead with foreign governments not to make him face the media; he pleads, but they don’t listen; then they publicly mock him by revealing that they ignored him; and yet, he won’t fight back — because he is compromised.”

“This is not just about Narendra Modi. It is the office of India’s Prime Minister that is being diminished and disrespected. And Modi deserves every bit of condemnation for bringing us to this point,” Khara said.

## Tough conversion law kicks in this week, Mumbai pastors ask churchgoers to sign form

and in some cases an FIR follows.

Seven of the nine FIRs are against those who organised the prayers and worshippers, two are against Bajrang Dal members.

An illustrative case is from April 12 in Vasai East, where a Sunday prayer meeting at Dhiraj Shopping Centre, attended by an estimated 100 to 150 people, was disrupted when a group of men, among them Bajrang Dal members, entered the hall. What followed over the next 24 hours was five FIRs at Achole police station, four against the person who conducts the meetings and one against his accusers.

It is against this backdrop that the forms have taken hold, described by organisers less as paperwork than as insurance.

At New Hope Church in Virar, which has recently built an iron grille gate that stays locked during prayers, Pastor Steven Rozario, 49, handed out the forms during a Sunday service this month and explained why. Around 30 people were present.

“This is a self-declaration form. I want all of you to fill it out, attach a passport-size photograph, and bring it with you next Sunday when we meet for prayer. Considering the continuous disruptions and attacks during prayer meetings, we are keeping these forms with us so that if someone questions us in the future and claims that we were forced or compelled you to attend the prayer meeting, we can show this as proof,” he told the congregation.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Rozario said pastors had held several meetings after the recent incidents. “In most cases, police do not even register FIRs against those who

break the law,” he said.

### Caution and ‘precaution’

For those signing, it is unfamiliar territory. Anita Patel, 55, a resident of Virar, said she has followed Christianity for 16 years and this was the first time she had been asked to declare in writing that she was attending voluntarily.

“Earlier, there was a freedom to choose and believe what we wanted to follow, and nobody questioned us about why we were following a particular faith. It is strange that I have to fill out such a form. It feels as though I no longer have the freedom to follow what I want to,” she said. “But it is okay; considering the current situation and the attacks on prayer meetings, this is perhaps the only way to live.”

Robin Alexander, 41, who sings during the service at New Hope Church in Virar, called it a precautionary measure. “It is good that we have this form. It is for our protection and is proof that we are coming here of our own free will and are not being forced,” he said.

Devdan Tribhuvan, state president of the Maharashtra Christian Development Association, said the forms were introduced as a security measure after people attending prayer meetings began being questioned, threatened and, in some cases, saw services disrupted.

“The allegations of conversion were already being made, so we started taking a simple declaration to make it clear that people were attending the prayer meeting of their own free will. It is purely for security purposes. The forms are not government documents; they are signed by the person and kept with the pastor,” he said.

He said the choice to attend a place of worship was protected by consent. “There is no allurement or compulsion. If I am a Christian, I can choose to go to any church in Mumbai,” he said. Churches have also started using CCTV cameras

and taking photographs, Tribhuvan added, because those involved in disruptions are often unidentified when FIRs are registered.

The Bajrang Dal claims it acts within the law. Gautam Ravariya, the outfit’s Konkan region co-convenor, said it monitors prayer meetings on social media and informs police rather than acting alone. He acknowledged FIRs had also been registered against its members.

“Four workers are attacked, they will defend themselves. We are not going there either to get beaten or to beat anyone, but self-defence is everyone’s right,” he said. Ravariya alleged some prayer groups first provide assistance to vulnerable families and then encourage them to convert.

When contacted, Niket Kaushik, Commissioner of the Mira Bhayandar Vasai-Virar Police, whose jurisdiction covers Vasai East, where five of the nine FIRs were registered, said: “There was one local incident in the past few months related to the issue and necessary action was taken. We have not seen any recurring instances to call it a trend.”

When asked about the form that prayer groups and churches are asking attendees to fill, he said, “We are unaware of any such consent form.”

On July 2, representatives of Mumbai for Peace and 24 civil society organisations met Mumbai Police Joint Commissioner (Law and Order) Manoj Kumar Sharma, seeking preventive action over repeated disruptions. “There is a pattern. People attend prayer meetings, then call in groups of 40 to 60 people. This has been happening repeatedly over the past three to four months,” said Dolphy D’Souza, spokesperson for the Bombay Catholic Sabha.

On the forms, D’Souza: “We do not know how much they will help, but what options do we have at this point? Churches and prayer places are open to everyone—people come to

pray for peace of mind, with friends, or because they have a particular prayer or wish. So, these forms are essentially intended to protect the church’s interests.”

### Making the law clear

Mumbai Police Joint Commissioner (Law and Order) Manoj Kumar Sharma, said, “There have been a few incidents in Mumbai which I remember, complaints were filed from both sides, we had given warning to those who were disrupting prayers, otherwise Mumbai has been peaceful and no such incidents have occurred recently. Yes, we have received the memorandum from Mumbai for Peace and if any such incidents occur we will take action accordingly, our team is also investigating those complaints.”

Church leaders are worried the disruptions may grow once the law takes effect. The legislation criminalises religious conversion brought about through coercion, fraud, force, threats, misrepresentation, inducement or undue influence, and covers conversions allegedly linked to marriage or a promise of marriage. It places the onus on the person facilitating the conversion to establish it was voluntary and prescribes stricter punishment when the alleged conversion involves a minor, woman, member of a Scheduled Caste or Scheduled Tribe, or a person of unsound mind. The state notified the law on July 31.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* on the consent form, Fr. Nigel Barrett, spokesperson for the Archdiocese of Bombay, said, “Taking a consent form is a wise precaution...It establishes that people are attending voluntarily and that no one is forcing them to come. Given the current law and the manner in which certain groups, such as the Bajrang Dal, enter these spaces, people are taking precautions to safeguard themselves.”

## OBC creamy layer candidates

incoming batch vis-à-vis subsequent recruitment cycles, it warned.

The government stated that “a mechanical or unqualified application of the ratio of the said judgement, with retrospective effect, to the already-concluded selection process of CSE-2025, would result in a peculiar and acute anomaly amounting to discrimination inter se candidates of the very examination cycle sought to be benefited”.

The government move comes ahead of crucial Assembly elections, with anti-reservation protests underway at some places.

The matter traces its origins to a DoPT letter of October 14, 2004, clarifying an Official Memorandum (OM) of September 1993 on the creamy layer criterion for OBCs. The 1993 OM had excluded income from salary and agricultural sources from the income/wealth test used to determine creamy layer status. However, the 2004 clarification said the salary income of employees in public sector undertakings (PSUs) and the private sector would be a criterion.

As per the petitioners, this was “hostile discrimination” between the wards of government servants and those of PSUs or private sector employees.

The 2004 clarification was not implemented effectively until 2014, while the UPA government was in power and was making efforts to consolidate OBC support. It began to be applied rigorously from the CSE-2015 (corresponding to the 2016 batch).

Since then, around 100 candidates who possessed caste certificates issued by competent authorities and cleared the CSE have found their OBC claims rejected by the DoPT on the creamy layer ground. Most of them are parties in different petitions before the Supreme Court and various High Courts.

Interestingly, some of these candidates successfully claimed OBC status in other examinations conducted by the Union Public Service Commission or state bodies, but were rejected in

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the CSE process.

On March 11 this year, hearing an appeal by one of the candidates, Rohith Nathan, a Division Bench of Justices P S Narasimha and R Mahadevan ruled that income cannot be the sole criterion for determining the creamy layer among OBCs. The Court said: “The object of excluding the creamy layer is... not to create artificial distinction between equally placed members of the same social class... unequal treatment of similarly placed OBC candidates would not only be legally erroneous but constitutionally impermissible.”

It further held that treating the children of those employed in PSUs or private employment as excluded from reservation benefits solely on the basis of salary income, without reference to the nature of their posts (Group A, B, C or D), “would certainly lead to hostile discrimination between parties who are similarly placed and would amount to equals being treated unequally, thereby attracting the rigour of the equality doctrine under Articles 14, 15 and 16”.

The Supreme Court gave six months time for the implementation of its judgment, which is set to get over on September 11.

DoPT sources told *The Indian Express* that the government had been all set to implement the Supreme Court verdict and that verification of documents of all affected candidates had already been completed.

If the March 11 judgment is implemented in full, its benefits would extend not only to candidates appearing in future examinations but also to those affected in earlier cycles. The implementation could hence lead to revised ranks for some.

In its application, the Centre has urged the Supreme Court to also “clarify/direct that the judgement shall not be applied retrospectively so as to unsettle completed admissions in higher educational institutions, completed academic sessions, degrees already conferred, or settled rights of students”.

## J&K reopens probe into 1998 massacre of 23 Kashmiri Pandits

that truth prevails and those responsible are brought to justice.”

The massacre dates back to 1998. On the night of January 25-26 in 1998, a militant group wearing army fatigues appeared in Wandhama village in central Kashmir’s Ganderbal district.

They engaged in conversation with Kashmiri Pandits and asked them to assemble at one place, before opening fire and killing 23 people, including four children and nine women.

The victims belonged to four families who had stayed back and not migrated from Kashmir when militancy erupted in the Valley in early 1990. They also included five guests who had come from Jammu to visit their relatives in Wandhama.

The police blamed Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) for the massacre. The killings triggered protests by Kashmiri Pandits across Jammu and Delhi. On January 26, 1998, protestors in Delhi marched towards the National Human Rights Commission and clashed with police, leading to injury to nine protestors.

The then Prime Minister, Inder Kumar Gujral, flew to Kashmir and then to Wandhama to join the mourners, accompanied by then Principal Secretary N N Vohra, J&K Chief Minister Farooq Abdullah and Governor K V Krishna Rao.

The police investigation in the case didn’t make any significant progress and it was closed.

The reopening of the Wandhama massacre is the latest case reopened by the investigating agency. Sources say that it has also reopened the case related to the murder of Tika Lal Taploo.

Taploo was killed on September 13, 1989, and is considered the first targeted killing in the Valley. The 59-year-old Taploo, an advocate by profession, was the BJP’s Vice President for Jammu and Kashmir and also a member of the Rash-

triya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS).

Over the last three years, the investigating agency has reopened several cases related to the killings of the Kashmiri Pandits. In 2023, the agency reopened the case of Neelkanth Ganjoo. A retired judge, Ganjoo was killed on November 4, 1989, in Srinagar. He is believed to have been targeted as he had sentenced Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front founder Maqbool Bhat to death in 1968. Bhat was finally hanged in 1984 and buried inside Tihar Jail.

In August, 2025, the SIA reopened the case of Sarla Bhat, a Kashmiri Pandit nurse working at the Sher-e-Kashmir Institute of Medical Sciences (SKIMS) in Srinagar. She was abducted by terrorists from her hostel on April 18, 1990, and her body was found the next day with multiple bullet wounds.

While there has not been much progress in Ganjoo’s case, the SIA has filed a chargesheet in the killing of Bhat and charged five JKLF operatives, including its chief Yasin Malik.

In 2017, the Supreme Court had dismissed a petition by Roots in Kashmir, a Kashmiri Hindu organisation, to re-open and investigate the killing of Kashmiri Pandits in the Valley. A bench comprising the then Chief Justice J S Khehar and Justice D Y Chandrachud had said that with nearly three decades having passed since the Pandit exodus from the Valley, evidence “is unlikely to be available”.

The petition had sought “transfer of all the FIRs/cases pertaining to murders of Kashmiri Pandits” by militants since the inception of insurgency out of J&K, and their handling by “some other independent investigating agency like the CBI or NIA”.

A curative petition filed by Roots of Kashmir was also dismissed by the apex court in 2022.

Seven months after the petition was dismissed, the SIA opened the first case, of Ganjoo.



STUDENTS SAY 8 DEATHS BY SUICIDE SINCE 2023, RAGE AT DEANS, DEMAND COMPENSATION

# ‘We are here after eight deaths’: Rare protest at IIT Delhi as student’s suicide sparks anger

Pragynesh  
New Delhi, August 24

AT 9 a.m. on Monday, students began gathering near the Lecture Hall Complex at the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Delhi. By evening, nearly 300 of them had moved to the first-floor lobby of the institute's main building, outside the director's office, demanding accountability from the administration. For a campus where student protests are an unusual sight, the mobilisation was striking. The protest came two days after a 31-year-old MSc Physics student, Rishikesh, died allegedly by suicide after jumping from the sixth floor of a building on the campus. Students said his death was the eighth suicide at the institute since 2023, and demanded the resignation of a Dean and Associate Deans, along with an independent inquiry and compensation for his family. “Wearen't hereafter onesui-

cide. Not after two. We are here after eight. How is it not enough for them?” a student said. The morning began around the Lecture Hall Complex, where students gathered and discussed their demands. Among them were the resignation of Professor Sreedevi Upadhyaula, Associate Dean of Student Welfare, an inquiry into the deaths, and Rs 1 crore in compensation for Rishikesh's family. After a brief silence in memory of Rishikesh, students began talking about what they described as a pattern of “administrative indifference”. “Rishikesh had taken a semester-long withdrawal after his father's death earlier this year because of mental health difficulties. He underwent treatment for more than a month,” a student said. “When he returned to the hostel in late July, however, his name had been removed from the hostel rolls because of



The students' protest on Monday. EXPRESS

his withdrawal,” another student said. Students alleged that despite fitness clearances from the hospitals where he had been treated, Rishikesh was asked to obtain another clearance from the IIT Delhi hospital before he could be allotted a room. “He was eventually forced to stay in rented accommodation outside the campus with his mother,” a student said. “Whenever we try to talk about problems, they tell us, ‘You should leave if you can't cope.’ They have a lack of empathy,” another student said, while protesting. The administration had cancelled all classes on Monday as the protest gathered momentum. By late afternoon, the centre of the demonstration had

shifted from the Lecture Hall Complex to the main building. By 5 p.m., the first-floor lobby outside IIT Delhi Director Rangan Banerjee's office had become the heart of the protest. Around 300 students had gathered there. Banerjee had already received the students' list of demands and was meeting representatives, along with Professor Sreedevi. At about 5:30 p.m., Banerjee emerged from his office. The students cheered. He announced that an inquiry committee would be constituted. But he also said that Professor Sreedevi would not resign at that point. The cheers quickly turned into hoots. Professor Sreedevi was escorted out through a back entrance of the building. “If she can't face us, how will she solve our problems?” one student asked. Another student said: “If we lose a credit, we are punished. Why is she not being punished? If we don't feel safe talking to her, what's the point of her being in that chair?” On the question of compensation, Banerjee said Rs 6 lakh, along with all medical expenses incurred by Rishikesh, would be paid to his single mother. The announcement drew little comfort from the crowd. “What is a single mother supposed to do with that? They were struggling financially anyway,” a student said. According to a preliminary police inquiry, Rishikesh entered the IIT Delhi campus through the main gate at around 8 a.m. on Saturday. He then went to the Lecture Hall Complex and took a lift to the sixth floor before allegedly jumping from the front side of the building, a senior police officer said. His death was the second alleged suicide at the institute this year. In March, a 19-year-old BTech student was found dead inside his apartment on the campus.

## Nearly 33L electors in Capital to get notices to prove eligibility as SIR enters next phase

Devansh Mittal  
New Delhi, August 24

STARTING AUGUST 31, 33 lakh electors in Delhi are set to get notices to prove their eligibility as the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) enters the next phase, sources involved in the exercise told *The Indian Express*. Those getting the notice will be asked to furnish one of the 13 documents listed by the Election Commission (EC), which includes birth certificate, passport, caste certificate and a permanent residence certificate. These are 34% of the roughly 97 lakh electors who had submitted their forms in the enumeration phase of the SIR when the booth level officers (BLOs) conducted door-to-door visits. After the visits, the BLOs upload these enumeration forms on the Election Commission's portal. The office of the Chief Electoral Office (CEO) also announced the completion of the rationalisation of polling stations in the Capital on Monday. Polling stations have been increased from 13,033 to 14,947 to ensure that each polling station has roughly 1,200 electors each. When the exercise started in June, Delhi had 1.45 crore names on its electoral rolls. Forms of around 47 lakh electors were marked uncollectible — a category that includes people who are absent, have shifted, have died, have duplicate entries, or fall under 'Other' reasons and will not find a place in the draft electoral roll set to be published on August 31. Out of the 33 lakh electors, who will be on the draft electoral rolls but are set to get notices, around 14 lakh are expected to get notices because their details could not be linked to the 2002 SIR roll, said sources. Nineteen lakh notices are set to be sent out due to anomalies found in the enumeration forms. These anomalies include the name of the electors in the current electoral roll not matching with the name in the last intensive revision roll; less than 15 year age gap between elector and parent; more than 50 year age gap between elector and parent; less than 9 month gap between birth date of siblings, among other reasons. The notice phase for disposal of claims and objection phase will last from August 31 to October 29. The final electoral rolls will be published on November 4. The Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) — usually a subdivisional magistrate who is senior to the BLO — may ask for additional documents if not satisfied about the electors' age (must be above 18) or citizenship (only Indian citizens are eligible to vote). An Aadhaar Card alone is not enough. It is the only document in the list that, by itself, will not suffice to prove eligibility, the EC has said. It must be accompanied by another document from the list that establishes the electors' age and citizenship. For those born in India before July 1, 1987, the EC requires a document proving date and/or place of birth. For those born between July 1, 1987, and December 2, 2004, the EC requires a document for the elector and one parent. For those born after December 2, 2004, the EC requires documents for the elector and both parents. These categories follow the requirements under the Citizenship Act, 1955.



# Schools, shops hit, Capital sees massive waterlogging & snarls

Sophiya Mathew  
& Mishal Mussaddique  
New Delhi, August 24

SCHOOLGIRLS WADING through waist-deep murky water, holding onto each other for balance, and pushing a stalled white school van at an inundated neighborhood road — this is how the morning started in Southeast Delhi’s Sangam Vihar on Monday for some students.

Just down the road, at the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) primary school in Deoli, which caters to nearly 800 children across two shifts, chaotic scenes unfolded as the morning bell rang. While teachers and staff reported for duty, classes had to be abruptly called off after heavy downpour submerged the school ground under deep, muddy water that did not recede even by late evening.

Across Delhi-NCR, heavy rain triggered widespread disruption, waterlogging and traffic jams, causing inconvenience to residents and commuters. At Safdarjung base station in the Capital, 34.6 mm of rain was reported between 8:30 am and 8:30 pm. According to IMD officials, Janakpuri and Ayanagar recorded the highest rainfall at 70 mm and 66 mm, respectively.

## Road caves in, parts of city flooded

Speaking to *The Indian Express* on the flooding of the ground, a senior official at the Deoli school on condition of anonymity said, “During the monsoon, this happens at least twice or thrice a month.” He attributed this to a maintenance-related issue of the school’s rain water harvesting system.

The surrounding belt of Durga Vihar, Deoli, and Sangam Vihar also saw pervasive flooding, engulfing narrow alleyways. At Main Market Durga Vihar and A-block basement commercial shops remained shut with water accumulating at doorsteps, while on Ashoka Avenue and Raju Park in C Block, residents struggled to drive through the narrow streets.

“I have lived here for 50 years, and the neglect remains the same,” said Shanti (70), a resident of Raju Park.

“Earlier this month, residents had to pool their own money to lay a drainage pipe because repeated appeals to departments yielded no progress. Just recently, a small child fell into an open drain and was about to drown before a passerby pulled him out.”

In C Block Deoli Pahadi Road, a section of the road caved in amid the downpour, prompting Delhi Jal Board (DJB) to

rush for emergency repairs. In Deoli village, resident Jagdish Anand alleged that house walls have developed cracks due to delayed sewer excavations.

The recurrent flooding in Sangam Vihar and adjoining settlements stems from several reasons. DJB in multiple submissions previously informed the National Green Tribunal (NGT) that sewer laying across parts of Sangam Vihar face severe delays.

Key bottlenecks include forest-land restrictions requiring clearances from the Ridge Management Board, pending road-cutting permissions, and local encroachments. While peripheral trunk sewers exist along main arterial routes, internal feeder connectivity lags, with deadlines in several pockets pushed to 2027. The resulting mix of sewage and stormwater regularly chokes natural outflow. As per officials, ongoing Phase-IV Delhi Metro construction work near Sainik Farms has also temporarily disrupted local drainage, with construction barricades trapping runoff and triggering severe waterlogging and vehicular logjams at the Deoli Mor intersection.

## Deja vu at Sadar Bazar

In Central Delhi’s wholesale hub of Sadar Bazar, scenes were

eerily reminiscent of last month’s inundation. Along the Qutub Road–Teliwara Akhara stretch, porters submerged waist-deep hauled heavy commercial goods on their heads and backs to dry ground, while shopkeepers frantically bailed water out of flooded basements.

MCD officials noted that Sadar Bazar relies on an aging combined drainage system with limited capacity.

Responding to the citywide waterlogging, Public Works Department (PWD) officials said intensive pre-monsoon preparedness and field monitoring have helped reduce critical waterlogging spots across Delhi from 194 to 65, and recurrent locations from 53 down to 20.

To clear the accumulated water, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) deployed one dewatering pump, PWD positioned two to three pumps near Azadpur Market Chowk, and the MCD pressed a tractor-mounted pump alongside a diesel unit provided to the RWA. Iron safety covers were placed over three open manholes at Teliwara to prevent accidents, with joint field inspections scheduled with PWD consultants to integrate the stretch into Phase I of the comprehensive drainage master plan.

## EXPRESS special

# ‘Your account funded Naresh Goyal’: Couple loses life savings in digital arrest scam

Pragynesh  
New Delhi, August 24

ON THE afternoon of April 17, a retired Armyman was settling in for a siesta at his home in Southwest Delhi’s Munirka when the landline in the hall rang. “You have not paid your electricity bill. Call this number or the connection will be cut,” the caller said. He gave the 78-year-old man a number before hanging up. The man thought it was odd since he had already paid his bill. He and his wife lived alone.

Their two daughters were married and settled in Dubai. Unsure whom to check with, he thought of his children but decided it would be pointless to make an international call over something so trivial.

So, he called the number.

It was the beginning of a 48-hour digital arrest in which the couple would be harried, cornered, isolated and finally coerced into handing over their entire savings Rs 15.5 lakh to men posing as CBI officers using an old trick — the Jet Airways founder Naresh Goyal case.

## The call from Mumbai

Police said when the retired Armyman called the number, a voice told him that his name had surfaced in a money laundering case involving Goyal.

“We have found that you gave your account details to Goyal, and all his money was sent to foreign accounts through your account,” he was told, according to police officers. The retired Armyman said he

## • HIGH-VALUE SCAMS OF 2026

**JAN:** The biggest cybercrime of 2026 in Delhi, till May 2026, involved a Rs 14-crore digital arrest of an octogenarian couple — Om Taneja, 81, and Indira, 77 — living in Greater Kailash.

**JAN:** A 70-year-old woman was duped of over Rs 7 crore in Delhi’s Greater Kailash after a week-long “digital arrest” by

scammers posing as ED officials.

**APRIL:** 76-year-old woman from Alaknanda in South Delhi was contacted by scammers claiming to be from Mumbai Police and the ED. They told her that her accounts had been used to fund the terrorist who carried out the Pahalgam attacks last year. She lost over Rs 43 lakh.



had no idea anything like this had happened. He then received a video call from a ‘CBI official in Mumbai’.

“A man appeared on screen, claiming to be DCP Anil Kumar from the CBI. He had a fake CBI office set up behind him, complete with a large emblem on the wall, and was wearing a uniform. He and another man, who he called SI Vijay, told the victim that he had been charged under the Foreign Exchange Management Act and Money Laundering Act,” said a police officer.

Police said that when the victim pleaded innocence, the men sent him photographs of places around his house — including the entrance to his society and a glass office building metres from his home.

“They told him that a team was in Delhi to arrest him unless he cooperated, and that was why they were sending these pictures. But the two men had downloaded the photographs from Google,” said an investigating officer. The couple were now

under digital arrest. Police said they were sent a fake notice from the Enforcement Directorate and asked to share their KYC details and medical records to ‘DCP Anil’ while remaining on video call.

On April 18, police said, the scammers claimed to have good news. “We have moved court for your anticipatory bail. But now your money needs to be verified. We will give you an RBI account number. You transfer whatever you have in it. The RBI will return it post verification,” the men told the victim, as per police. The victim transferred Rs 15.5 lakh, and was sent a ‘bail order’ from the Bombay High Court. The call was then cut. “When his money didn’t come back after two days of him constantly calling the scammers, he came to the police,” said the officer. A case was registered.

## Targeting the elderly

Officers said the spike in crimes against the elderly began in the new decade as families

became more nuclear.

As per an officer, almost every month in 2026, they have been seeing at least two to three major cyber frauds targeting elderly people. “The problem is even more severe in upscale localities. Scammers and robbers know that many of the people here are affluent, and their children are either in high-stakes jobs that keep them busy or they are in foreign countries,” said the officer.

The latest National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data backs the trend of crimes against senior citizens, with Delhi reporting more such cases than any other metro city in India. As per the data, crimes against senior citizens in Delhi dipped marginally, from 1,361 cases in 2023 to 1,267 in 2024. The city, however, continued to top the list among metropolitan cities. The 1,267 cases accounted for just over 30% of the 4,107 crimes against senior citizens reported in metropolitan cities. And the retired Armyman’s case is among the high-profile digital arrest cases registered in Delhi this year. (see box)

## Following the money

During their probe, police traced the Rs 15.50 lakh transferred by the victim to a current account in Ludhiana belonging to a man named Sarbjit, 38.

Police picked up Sarbjit for questioning. He allegedly told investigators that he had handed over the account to cyber fraudsters through an intermediary. That intermediary,

police said, was Suraj (30).

Suraj allegedly told investigators that he had been introduced to another man, Naresh alias Lucky, through Telegram and had ultimately passed the account and its banking kit to him. The trail then led investigators to Jaipur. Police said Sarbjit, Suraj and a third man, a bank official named Sandeep, travelled to Jaipur to hand over the account kit to Naresh.

Sandeep (32) allegedly used his banking-sector contacts and knowledge to facilitate the procurement of current accounts. Police suspect these accounts were then passed through several intermediaries before reaching cyber-fraud operators based abroad.

All three were arrested, and a police team subsequently nabbed Naresh from Rajasthan. During questioning, police said he allegedly admitted that he procured current accounts from Suraj through Telegram and supplied them to cyber-fraud operators based in Cambodia and the UAE.

This, police said, revealed the wider structure of the network — people willing to provide bank accounts for commissions, intermediaries who collect and transfer the accounts, and overseas operators who used them to receive proceeds of cyber fraud. Police, however, are yet to recover the money. Police said the current account was allegedly linked to 17 complaints involving fraudulent transactions running into crores.



## Security strategies meet: Focus on tackling terror & infiltration

Express News Service  
New Delhi, August 24

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah Monday inaugurated the ninth National Security Strategies Conference here to discuss key national security issues, including the detection and deportation of illegal migrants and proxy warfare by Pakistan.

According to a statement by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), discussions on the first day included counter-terrorism challenges, analysis and operationalisation of intelligence through the Multi-Agency Centre, a vision document on narcotics control, the detection and deportation of illegal migrants, a policy framework to combat cyber crime, and proxy warfare by Pakistan.

“For effective tackling of terrorism and radicalisation, Shah emphasised training for implementation of MHA’s PRAHAAR scheme, exped-



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during the inauguration of the ninth National Security Strategies Conference-2026.

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ting trials by bringing back fugitives and using trial-in-absentia provisions, and adopting a comprehensive and integrated approach while investigating UAPA cases,” the spokesperson said.

During discussion, Shah has also directed that AI-based analysis of information available on MAC platforms be carried out to create standard operating procedures, the spokesperson said.

Shah also directed agencies to take strict measures against infiltration, the spokesperson added. The second day of the conference will focus on the threat landscape from sub-aerial systems, securing the blue economy, information warfare, and the need for a bio-security framework, the spokesperson highlighted. The National Security Strategies Conference has been held every year since 2021.

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Abhishek moves apex court for early decision by Speaker on rebels’ disqualification

Press Trust of India  
New Delhi, August 24

TRINAMOOL CONGRESS general secretary and Lok Sabha leader Abhishek Banerjee has approached the Supreme Court seeking an expeditious decision by Speaker Om Birla on petitions seeking disqualification of 20 rebel party MPs who have aligned themselves with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India.

According to the SC website, a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana has listed Banerjee’s plea for hearing on August 25.

The top court is also seized of a similar plea filed by the Shiv Sena (UBT) challenging the Speaker’s approval to the merger of its six MPs with the Shiv Sena led by Maharashtra Deputy CM Eknath Shinde. A bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Alok Aradhe is hearing that petition.

Banerjee, in his plea, challenged the alleged delay in deciding the disqualification proceedings initiated against the MPs. The TMC leader has sought directions for the Speaker to decide the disqualification petitions in accordance with the anti-defection provisions of the Constitution. He had earlier submitted separate petitions against the 20 MPs and subsequently urged the Speaker to expedite their disposal.



● KUNNUMMAL'S APPOINTMENT, WHICH HAS BEEN CHALLENGED BY BOTH CONGRESS AND CPI(M), HAS BEEN VIEWED AS THE GOVERNOR'S STEP TOWARDS 'SAFFRONISING' HIGHER EDUCATION IN THE STATE

# Who is Mohanan Kunnummal, Kerala V-C at centre of repeated controversies

**Shaju Philip**  
*Thiruvananthapuram, August 24*

“ARE YOU cockroaches or lions?” Kerala University of Health Sciences (KUHS) Vice-Chancellor Dr Mohanan Kunnummal repeatedly asked students during a recent award ceremony in Thiruvananthapuram.

When a video of students sitting unresponsive went viral, it added a new episode to the growing controversies around Kunnummal, who has found himself at the centre of recurring tensions between the Governor's office and Kerala government, of the Left and now the Congress, over the last few years. A medical professional

specialising in radio-diagnosis for the last three decades, Kunnummal, who is also the V-C of the University of Kerala, on August 22 alleged that “foreign forces” were trying to convert young people to cockroaches. This cockroach controversy came close on the heels of Kunnummal's remark on *Vande Mataram* at an RSS Sankalp youth summit on Independence Day. Reacting to the Congress-led government's decision to skip the recital of *Vande Mataram* at Kerala's official Independence Day events, Kunnummal said, “When we pray, we say *Vande Mataram*. It is our mother and those who oppose *Vande Mataram* do not know who their mother is.” Over the years, both the

CPI(M) and Congress have challenged Kunnummal's appointments — first as the V-C of KUHS in 2019 and then the additional charge as the V-C of the University of Kerala in 2023 — as part of the Governor's “saffronisation of higher education” in Kerala. In October 2019, then Governor Arif Mohammed Khan picked Kunnummal as the V-C of KUHS, allegedly overlooking the recommendations of a search committee formed by the then Left government. After then Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan assumed office for the Left government's second consecutive term in 2021, the higher education sector had been marked by repeated tussles between the Governor



Kunnummal is the V-C of Kerala University of Health Sciences and Kerala University

and the state government. The first battle ground was the University of Kerala in 2022, when Khan formed a search committee for a new V-C as the

incumbent Dr Mahadevan Pillai's tenure was coming to an end. The University Senate, dominated by CPI(M) members, did not name its nominee to the search committee in protest against the Governor's earlier action. Khan then gave Kunnummal the additional charge as the V-C of the University of Kerala. In 2024, when his five-year tenure as V-C of KUHS was to end, Kunnummal was reappointed for another term by Khan — until then, it had been unusual in Kerala to reappoint a V-C. The only precedent came in 2021, when Kannur University V-C Dr Gopinath Ravindran was given another term by Khan, who claimed he had acted at the behest of the

CPI(M) government. In 2023, the Supreme Court quashed Ravindra's reappointment. As the power struggle between the government and Khan continued over the University of Kerala, Kunnummal as the acting V-C got involved in nominations for the University Senate with Khan's backing. In 2024, Khan extended Kunnummal's tenure as V-C “till a permanent V-C was appointed” at the University of Kerala. When the CPI(M) members in the Senate legally challenged the decision, the Kerala High Court upheld the Governor's move, which led to Kunnummal's continuation as the V-C. After Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar replaced Khan as the

Kerala Governor in January 2025, Kunnummal had drawn the ire of the Left government over a portrait of Bharat Mata with a saffron flag at a function attended by Arlekar. On June 25, 2025, socio-cultural outfit Sree Padmanabha Seva Samithi marked 50 years since the Emergency with an event at the University of Kerala attended by Arlekar. University registrar Anil Kumar, who had ordered the cancellation of the programme over a Bharat Mata portrait displayed at a university hall, was suspended by Kunnummal. The incident had sparked protests with the Left alleging that Kunnummal was “proving his loyalty to the RSS”. Things have not changed

much since the Congress-led UDF came to power in May this year. In June, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat addressed a lecture series in Thiruvananthapuram titled “100 Years of Sangh Journey: New Horizons”. The event was attended not only by Kunnummal, but also by two other vice-chancellors — MG University V-C in-charge Dr D Mavoothu and Malayalam University V-C in-charge Dr CR Prasad. Chief Minister V D Satheesan said the attendance of the three V-Cs at Bhagwat's event was a “serious lapse” and was not in tune with the state's educational tradition and the dignity of the V-C's post. However, months later, Kunnummal was in attendance at another RSS event on Independence Day.



# Suvendu: 10% of CAA applicants got citizenship so far

Express News Service  
Kolkata, August 24

CHIEF MINISTER Suvendu Adhikari on Monday said that out of the 2.3 lakh people who applied for citizenship under the amended citizenship law (CAA) in the state, 23,000 (or 10 percent) have been issued citizenship certificates so far, and asserted that hearing of applications will be completed soon.

“This was our promise. We are implementing it. As a result, Hindu refugees who have applied for citizenship will be issued certificates quickly,” the CM told mediapersons at Nabanna, the state secretariat.

Notably, only a few days ago, the Centre had issued guidelines assigning the responsibility of issuing citizenship certificates to the district magistrates. Adhikari said, “Through the district magistrates, we will act quickly. Of the 2.30 lakh people, 23,000 have received certificates. And those who have not yet applied will still be able to do so. We will also be able to complete the hearings swiftly and issue certificates to Hindu refugees who came from Bangladesh due to religious persecution.”

“Our Hindu refugees, the Matua community, who have long been waiting in hope and brought us to power, will receive the certificates from me. The Government of India has entrusted this responsibility to me,” he said, while also denying allegations of discrimination in transferring money to women beneficiaries of the Annapurna

cash-transfer scheme. “Those who are eligible will receive the money (under the Annapurna scheme). Out of nearly 1.45 crore beneficiaries, 19.2 lakh are Muslim families. We do not discriminate. The government has records of what appeasement was practised during the previous (TMC) administration. One lakh eligible women beneficiaries in the Hills of Darjeeling have received financial assistance,” Adhikari said amid reports of protests by women in several parts of the state over non-payment of the scheme money.

Reacting to the last week-end’s clashes on Jadavpur University campus that took place between ABVP, the RSS’ students’ wing, and CPI(M)’s SFI, the CM said, “Normal classes have been held at Jadavpur University. There is no problem there. This will not be tolerated here. One must engage in nationalist activities. Things like ‘Red Salute’ to (Maoist leader) Kishenji will not be allowed.” He said that he will personally visit the JU campus next Friday and sing ‘Vande Mataram’ there.

Adhikari once again targeted the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress. “A lot remains to be done. The corrupt aunt-nephew duo was at the peak of corruption. The harshest punishment will be given to thieves. The work of confiscating the property acquired through theft, auctioning it, and returning it to the government treasury is still pending,” Adhikari said. “Can everything be done in 110 days? It has only been three months.”

# Why Bihar wants the Farakka treaty scrapped — and why it puts Govt in a bind

Santosh Singh  
Patna, August 24

A FRESH diplomatic and political confrontation is brewing in Bihar over the 1996 India-Bangladesh Ganges Water Sharing Treaty, or known colloquially as the Farakka treaty. As the treaty’s lapse approaches, Bihar’s ruling National Democratic Alliance is pushing against its renewal — a development that could put the BJP-led Centre in a bind.

In the latest push against the pact, Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Kumar Choudhary, who handles the state’s water resources portfolio and who had accompanied CM Samrat Choudhary during a recent meeting with External Affairs

Minister S. Jaishankar in Delhi, told reporters that the state had “expressed our concerns regarding the Farakka treaty and how it has proved detrimental to Bihar’s interest”. “The Union minister assured us of taking care of our concerns,” he said.

This comes after JD(U) national working president and Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Kumar Jha also urged the Centre not to renew the pact. “The Farakka treaty has done enormous harm to Bihar. It is also surprising that the treaty was never reviewed in the last 30 years,” Jha told *The Indian Express*. “Bihar suffers floods, heavy siltation and also paucity of water because of it. Now that we are in the phase of industrialisation, we need rational use of water.

During summers, when we need water for ourselves, we have to concede water to Bangladesh as per the treaty.”

The Farakka Water Treaty (officially called the Ganges Water Sharing Treaty) is a bilateral deal signed on December 12, 1996, between India and Bangladesh that regulates the sharing of the Ganga waters at the Farakka Barrage in West Bengal, India, primarily during the dry season from January 1 to May 31. The treaty expires in December.

The barrage was built in 1975 to divert water from the Ganga into the Hooghly River to flush out silt and to keep Kolkata Port navigable. However, this reduced downstream river flow into Bangladesh, causing severe water shortages, increased soil



The treaty has done enormous harm to Bihar: JD(U) working president and RS MP Sanjay Kumar Jha, who has urged the Centre not to renew the pact

salinity, and ecological stress in southern Bangladesh. The 1996 treaty established a 30-year bind-

ing framework (1996–2026) to replace earlier short-term stopgap arrangements and ensure predictable water distribution.

Unlike the earlier 1977 temporary deal, the 1996 treaty lacks a “minimum flow guarantee clause”. If total flow falls drastically below 50,000 cusecs, the treaty only calls for immediate emergency consultations between both governments. Siltation, reduced groundwater discharge, upstream water withdrawal, and erratic rainfall patterns have altered the river’s actual availability in Bihar compared to 1996 baseline levels.

For two decades, the Bihar government has been flagging concerns over the barrage with the Centre — first under Nitish Kumar and now under

Samrat Choudhary. The government argues that the structure has created a severe “flood-and-parch” dynamic upstream, and that the heavy silt trapped behind the barrage has drastically elevated the Ganges riverbed, destroying its natural water storage capacity and driving severe seasonal floods into surrounding districts like Bhagalpur and Munger during monsoons.

Pushing against renewal, Jha argued that Bihar’s projected water needs up to 2050 be prioritised and that any future diplomatic arrangement must include a comprehensive National Silt Management Policy and direct representation for the state.

The mounting domestic pressure from NDA coalition partner JD(U) comes at a deli-

cate moment for Delhi’s foreign policy. For his part, Jaishankar has stressed that neighbourhood relations must be navigated through “mutual interest” and “common ground”.

At a recent media conclave, Jaishankar, while responding to questions on complex bilateral issues — from Bangladesh’s demands for stronger downstream guarantee clauses to wider diplomatic discussions — noted that for any international relationship to function smoothly, both sides must establish a shared landing point.

But even as the state’s NDA alliance mounts pressure on the Centre, Bihar’s Principal Opposition, the Rashtriya Janata Dal, has been highlighting a 2011 parliamentary speech by

party chief Lalu Prasad in which he demanded the dismantling of the barrage.

“We are only reproducing what is already in the public domain. Now all eyes are on the NDA government at the Centre, which faces a tight balancing act between regional flood management at home and strategic neighbourhood diplomacy abroad,” an RJD leader told *The Indian Express*.

JD(U) chief spokesperson Neeraj Kumar dismissed this as “immaterial”. “Why had Lalu Prasad not opposed the treaty in 1996 when the RJD was backing the H D Deve Gowda government with 22 MPs? But what the RJD says and does now is not important — we want the dismantling of the Farakka Barrage.”





## Gor in Srinagar: A one-man mission to strengthen a sputtering relationship

**S**ERGIO GOR'S comment about Jammu and Kashmir being an important part of India has generated banner headlines, and understandably so.

Taken literally, his words go against decades of US policy on Kashmir. They are even more noteworthy than President Donald Trump's offer, made soon after Operation Sindoor last year, to work with India and Pakistan to help find a "solution" for Kashmir. That's because Trump's comments actually reflected a past US policy — one espoused in the initial years after 1947, when several administrations sought to help solve the Kashmir issue. The US posture has since evolved from working on it actively to taking a more hands-off role and welcoming any Indian and Pakistani efforts to resolve it themselves.

Additionally, this isn't just any US ambassador to India who made this comment. Gor is an ambassador who also serves as special envoy to South Asia, which gives him ample policy authority over both India and Pakistan. Even more important is that Gor is widely believed to be a close confidant of Trump's.

But as significant as Gor's statement was, it's important not to overstate the implications. This is likely more about Gor's desire to bolster US-India relations than it is about anything having to do with Kashmir.

Unsurprisingly, there's been Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

Recall that since Gor arrived in New Delhi in January, he has been on a one-man mission to strengthen a sputtering relationship. He has pursued high-level engagements in New Delhi and across Indian states. He has announced conciliatory measures, like inviting India to join the Pax Silica silicon supply-chain initiative after India initially didn't receive an invitation. His messaging about India and US-India ties has been unrelentingly positive, in contrast to the sharp criticism directed at India by the White House in the months before Gor took up his ambassadorial post.

Against this backdrop, we can see what was likely at play in Srinagar.

Gor was keen to keep up his positive messaging and broader charm offensive with New Delhi. By saying Kashmir is an "important part of India", he was giving it a handsome compliment and perhaps providing a US rationale for pursuing commercial cooperation with Kashmir — a goal identified by Gor in an X post shortly after his Kashmir visit. Additionally, more broadly, given his proximity to Trump, Gor may have been looking to say something that would go down well with the Indian business community, to help advance an evergreen objective of his boss — attract more foreign investment to the US.

Unsurprisingly, there's been



MICHAEL KUGELMAN

**It's also essential not to overstate the implications of Gor's comments for the US-India-Pakistan triangle**

no formal US statement announcing a new policy on Kashmir. To be sure, Washington also hasn't walked back Gor's comments or clarified that US policy on Kashmir remains the same. But this can perhaps be attributed to a view within US government circles that there's no reason whatsoever to interpret Gor's comments as a policy shift. After all, as several Indian analysts have noted, Gor used the word "important", as opposed to "integral". The latter term is the one often invoked by New Delhi when articulating its position on Kashmir. Additionally, the term "important" is not as closely associated with contexts linked to territoriality.

It's also essential not to overstate the implications of Gor's comments for the US-India-Pakistan triangle. True, Pakistan's foreign ministry summoned the US charge d'affaires, Nathalie Baker, soon after Gor's comments. But that move shouldn't be read as a threat to a resurgent US-Pakistan partnership. It's very unusual for a US official to say anything about Kashmir that goes against Pakistan's position. And this is Kashmir — what multiple Pakistani leaders have described as the country's "jugular vein".

In this sense, Islamabad had no choice but to rapidly summon Baker. But Pakistani officials have been quiet ever since. And that's no surprise; they have no

interest in rocking the boat with a US administration on which they badly want to remain on good terms, given its stated interest in capitalising on commercial opportunities in Pakistan — and in partnering in a range of spaces, from counterterrorism to peace mediation in the Middle East.

Meanwhile, Gor's comments may deliver a boost to US-India ties, but not much more than that.

The Indian government has said little about them publicly, and much of the messaging from Indian voices — from officials in Kashmir to prominent independent analysts — has essentially revolved around the view that what the US thinks about Kashmir ultimately doesn't matter, given that it's India's issue. This ho-hum reaction may also be a reflection of the trust gap in India when it comes to Washington these days — a problem that Gor, despite his best efforts, has so far been unable to fix.

Ultimately, given the significance of what Gor said and who he is, it would be wrong to dismiss all this as much ado about nothing. But at the end of the day, there's no change in policy or diplomatic alignments to speak of. It's just another case of an unconventional administration doing unconventional things.

*The writer is resident senior fellow for South Asia at Atlantic Council, Washington, DC*

## The Mecca pact is for joint defence. Against whom?



DP SRIVASTAVA

**T**HOUGH THERE is a pause in the shooting war, the situation in West Asia continues to be volatile. The Strait of Hormuz remains closed. Houthi attacks on the Bab el-Mandeb at the mouth of the Red Sea have closed the second waterway for the transport of Saudi oil to Asian markets. This also affects shipments of Russian crude oil to India. Amid these developments, Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan have signed the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement. This raises the question: Joint defence against whom? There could be three possible threats: The Houthis, Iran, and Israel.

The joint statement issued after the Makkah Al-Mukarramah Summit stipulates that "any armed attack against any of the three states shall be regarded as an attack against them all". However, the extent and nature of commitments by the three countries for joint defence are not known. Nor has the geographical scope of such an arrangement been spelt out. Will this include conflicts outside West Asia? Can Pakistan invoke it in case of an Indian riposte to a future terror attack?

Has the Mecca Agreement created an Islamic NATO? Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty provides for collective self-defence but limits its scope to Europe. The only time Article 5 was invoked was in Afghanistan, post 9/11. NATO's travails in Ukraine and absence in the Iran war point to the fact that what matters is common threat perception, not a formal pact. Within the Mecca Agreement, the threat perceptions differ. Houthi attacks on Red Sea shipping do not pose a direct threat to Turkey or Pakistan. Turkey is more concerned with the Israeli presence in Syria. Pakistan regards India and Afghanistan as threats. In 2015, Pakistan did not take part in the action against the Houthis despite requests from Saudi Arabia and the UAE.

Is the Mecca Agreement an alliance of Sunni powers against Shia Iran? Iran has emerged as the most important regional power, having withstood more than 23,000 Israeli and US bombing raids in the war. Can Turkey and Pakistan provide Saudi Arabia with the protection from Iranian retaliation that the US could not? However, they do not mind sharing Saudi riches. The accord gives Pakistan a diplomatic profile at a time when its economy is sinking and it is beset by internal problems in Balochistan and PoK. Saudi Arabia and Pakistan had signed a Strategic

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Mutual Defence Agreement (SMDA) last year. A Pakistan Air Force contingent and 13,000 ground troops were deployed in the eastern part of Saudi Arabia in April this year. Did the Pakistanis fire a single shot in discharge of their obligations under the SMDA?

The third possible threat is Israel. PM Netanyahu's pronouncement of a Greater Israel may have made Arab governments uncomfortable. However, the US umbrella could provide better protection to Saudi interests than Turkey could.

The trilateral pact has not gone unnoticed in Tehran. The influential daily Kayhan, close to the IRGC, has carried a strong editorial against Pakistan, questioning its credentials as a neutral mediator in Iran's talks with the US. In Pakistan, Shia cleric Jawad Naqvi has already criticised the government for joining the alliance.

India has friendly relations with Saudi Arabia. It is a good customer for Saudi oil. Saudi Arabia has a mature diplomatic establishment. It will nevertheless be useful to sensitise them to our concerns. If attacked, India is bound to exercise its right of self-defence.

The lasting solution to the West Asia crisis is mainstreaming Iran, so that it has a stake in a peaceful region. The June 17 MoU holds the promise of lifting both secondary and primary sanctions against Iran. This goes beyond the Obama-era nuclear deal. Iran's capacity to dominate Hormuz is tacitly recognised by all countries. This should be used as a deterrent against future aggression, rather than as a toll, which would bring a small fraction of the revenue Iran could earn from the export of its oil and petrochemicals once sanctions are lifted. The US should lift the blockade. The nuclear issue need not be insurmountable. Iran has already committed in the MoU to not "procure or develop nuclear weapons". The US has to moderate its demands. Insistence on "zero enrichment" will only be a deal-breaker. Iran has a legitimate sense of grievance. It was twice attacked by Israel and the US amid negotiations. But the future of its people is more important. The alternative to an agreement is continued disruption of global oil supplies, loss of revenue for the Gulf states and Iran, and chaos in West Asia.

*The writer is former ambassador to Iran. He negotiated the Chabahar Agreement*

## Counting out the disabled citizens



SHASHANK PANDEY



AARTI BATRA

**S**ELF-ENUMERATION for Census 2027 began on August 17 in Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand, ahead of door-to-door enumeration from September 1 and the national count in February 2027. Having examined the disability question, we find apprehensions of an undercount well-founded.

Question 13 asks whether the respondent is a person with disability and permits up to three selections from nine: Seeing, hearing, speech, mobility, intellectual disability, mental illness, acid attack, chronic neurological disease and, now, blood disorder. This appears to be an improvement: Nine categories rather than the eight of 2011, blood disorder introduced, and "mental retardation" replaced with "intellectual disability". But it is inadequate.

The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 expanded recognised conditions from seven to 21, including dwarfism, cerebral palsy, autism spectrum disorder and specific learning disabilities, each with entitlements such as certification, reservation and welfare. None will appear as a distinct category in the Census. Autism is often recorded as intellectual disability by certification boards lacking the capacity or intent to distinguish them. The Census mentions intellectual disability without a separate entry for autism and other developmental conditions, reproducing that error at national scale. This misidentification leads to real consequences in early interventions, education and employment.

The schedule has also regressed: The options for multiple disabilities and "any other" have been withdrawn, and it is unclear whether 13(b)'s three selections will be recorded as multiple disabilities or as duplicate counts. The options are the broad heads of the Disability Act, until acid attack appears, although the statute situated it within locomotor disability. Placing a narrow sub-condition beside an umbrella term like mobility raises the question of what governed this classification. The customary response — the Unique Disability ID database will supply what the Census omits — does not hold. UDID registration reaches only about half the disabled population as per the last Census figures. Census data is crucial to map this access gap. Enumeration is proceeding in districts where assessment infrastructure is thinnest and formal diagnosis rare due to lack of specialists. The training material has no adequate guidance on how to enquire when a respondent hesitates to disclose mental illness, or how an enumerator without clinical training might recognise intellectual disability.

Welfare allocations depend on disaggregated data. Parliament recognised thalassemia, haemophilia and sickle cell disease as distinct conditions. A single figure for blood disorder doesn't convey this, and neither the National Sickle Cell Anaemia Elimination Mission nor thalassemia care under the National Health Mission can be evaluated without a baseline. Specific learning disabilities, absent altogether, present another difficulty: Remediation must be available where most affected children live. Education departments are left with CSO estimates.

None of this required reinventing the Census, only aligning the question with the statute — by adopting all 21 recognised conditions or, at minimum, restoring multiple disabilities and a structured "other, please specify" — and training those who ask the questions. The Census returns once in a decade. If this occasion is missed, a generation of disabled Indians will grow up undercounted, underbudgeted and invisible to the state.

*Pandey is a lawyer and founder of the Politics and Disability Forum. Batra is co-founder of Believe in the Invisible*

**NATO's travails in Ukraine and absence in the Iran war point to the fact that what matters is common threat perception, not a formal pact. Within the Mecca Agreement, the threat perceptions differ**

**The training material has no adequate guidance on how to enquire when a respondent hesitates to disclose mental illness, or how an enumerator without clinical training might recognise intellectual disability**



# Could perverse incentives lead to inflated OBC numbers in Census? Answer is no

**DESHKAAL**

BY YOGENDRA YADAV

I RECEIVED a pleasant surprise last week. In an article in this newspaper ('Count caste by all means. But abandon belief that counting settles anything' *IE*, August 21), Surjit Bhalla, no *dimagi* Naxal by any stretch, endorsed the central claims I have been making in these pages on the caste census. Bhalla favours a caste census. And he does so for the right reasons: "Yes. Count caste — India allocates education and employment on caste." I have been arguing for years that it is a scandal for a country to have legally enforced quotas for a social group — the OBCs — and not count its population. Bhalla also shares my assessment that the caste census is now dead, actually being killed by the government: "Yadav is right that the [caste] Census is now being killed by design." And he agrees with my analysis of why the Modi government has done so: "His diagnosis of the politics [behind the technical choice of the wording of the caste question] is sort of persuasive."

I could not ask for more. I should have just posted his article on social media, while thanking and tagging him. But there is a technical twist in this tantalising tale. Bhalla wants me to realise that even in the absence of sabotage, the caste census would not have told us "the truth" and advises us to "abandon the belief that counting [castes] settles anything". This does disservice to his own position and begs a question: Why should we trouble the already burdened Census enumerator with this additional question if its answer does not settle "anything"?

Minus such verbal excesses, the main argument in Bhalla's article is fairly straightforward. Counting castes by using a drop-down menu of categories like SC/ST/OBC is bound to produce unreliable data. If the Cen-

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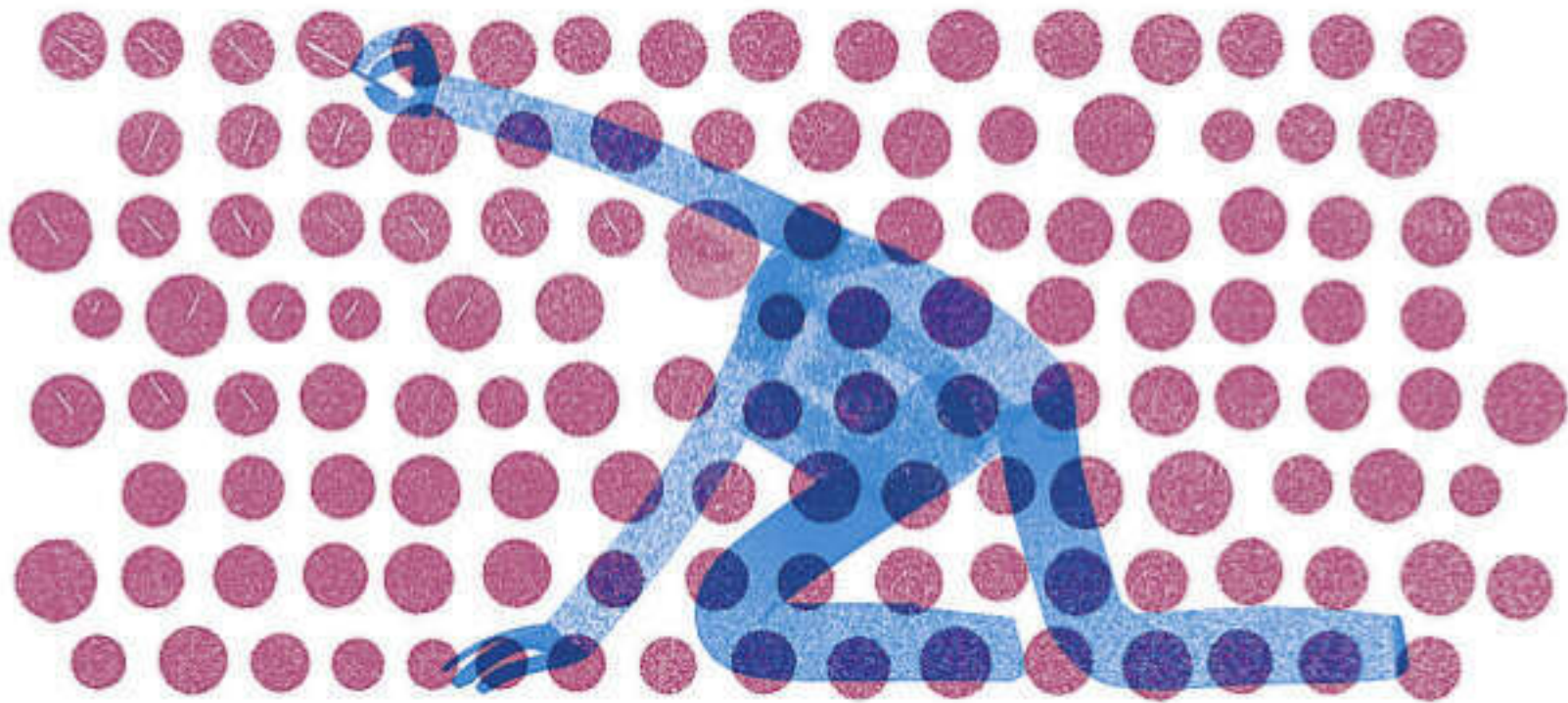


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

sus allows every person to choose a caste category, which is linked to his or her entitlements, we are creating a perverse incentive to lie, to claim membership of a category to which the person does not belong. This could lead to a massive exaggeration in the numbers for OBCs. Hence his suggestion: "Ask for caste, sub-caste and surname, never for category." He lays out a dazzling array of data to make an innocuous point: Human beings respond to incentives. Indeed, no proof was required for this.

Sadly, Bhalla chooses a bad example to make an otherwise valid point. He presents the unusual rise in the estimated population of OBCs between the 55th (1999-2000) and 61st (2004-05) rounds of the National Sample Survey as evidence of incentivised manipulation in caste numbers. He correctly shows that such a rise could not have happened due to an increase in population. But he wrongly assumes that this must have been caused by respondents falsely reporting OBC status to claim entitlements. He does not mention that 1999 was the first time OBCs were counted in the NSS and were thus prone to being under-counted. He does not examine a competing and compelling hypothesis: OBC was still a recent category in 1999, and many more OBCs were unfamiliar with it then compared to five years

**While dissecting data from 1999 and 2004, Bhalla does not share the figures for 2009-10, 2014 and 2017-18, which report a fairly stable share for OBCs — between 42 and 43 per cent**

later. Most importantly, while dissecting the data from 1999 and 2004, Bhalla does not care to share the NSS figures for 2009-10, 2014 and 2017-18, which report a fairly stable share for OBCs — between 42 and 43 per cent. If the respondents were over-reporting OBC status, why did this trend halt in 2004?

Regardless, let's stick to his general argument about perverse incentives that might lead to exaggeration of population numbers for the OBCs in the coming Census. That would be a valid apprehension if you do not know something basic about the Census of India, a surprising omission on Bhalla's part. Section 15 of the Census Act, 1948 guards the privacy of Census responses and says that Census records are not open to public scrutiny and cannot be used as evidence in a civil or criminal court. The Supreme Court has reiterated that no person can use his or her self-declaration in Census responses to claim entitlements, reservation, or any statutory benefits. In sum: There is zero individual incentive to misreport your category in the Census.

If not an individual one, is there a collective incentive for social groups to inflate their numbers in the Census to claim higher community benefits, say, a higher quota for OBCs? Hypothetically, yes. But why would the non-OBCs participate in such a conspiracy if there

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are no individual gains for misreporting? Besides, history belies such apprehensions: If entitlements incentivise lying in the Census, why has the population share of SCs and STs not leapt up beyond credible population trends in the last seven decennial censuses?

Now that the perverse incentive theory is laid to rest, may I invite Bhalla to rethink whatever remains of our difference on this issue. Although he does not spell out his alternative, it seems Bhalla does not favour an open-ended question on caste that simply records any answer offered by the respondent. As a seasoned survey researcher himself, Bhalla would know that it would be an invitation to a data disaster — millions of responses that defy post-coding. I understand his opposition is to a stand-alone caste category question — Are you SC/ST/OBC/General — as this method is vulnerable to large-scale errors. But that is not the proposal from the proponents of the caste census.

What we are suggesting is what survey researchers call a two-stage hierarchical question using cascading response categories. This is exactly how the question about SC and ST has always been asked in the census: First you are asked to choose a category, then presented with a list of caste names within that category to choose from. In case you chose the wrong category, the drop-down menu in the next question helps to rectify it there and then. So, our proposal is that the same should be extended this time to the OBCs and the General category. As for Bhalla's fair insistence that professional sociologists should be involved in classifying castes and sub-castes, I may again point out that this job has already been done by various commissions in the case of OBCs. And by the 43-volume *People of India* series by the Anthropological Survey of India for the rest. Why reinvent the wheel, if the desire is not to sabotage the caste count?

This is not meant to be a rebuttal. I really hope to persuade Surjit Bhalla, whose voice carries weight with the present dispensation, unlike mine.

*The writer is member, Swaraj India, and national convenor, Bharat Jodo Abhiyaan. Views are personal*

**AMIR HYDER KHAN**

DELHI'S AMBITIOUS Master Plan for 2047 promises new housing, transit-oriented development, economic corridors and expanded infrastructure as part of the larger project of making the capital a globally competitive city. But behind these targets lies a more fundamental question: Who gets to belong to the Delhi being built? Planning is often presented as a technical exercise involving land use, density and infrastructure. In reality, it determines who gets access to housing, employment and public space, who benefits from rising land values and who bears the costs of development.

The G20 Summit in 2023 offered a

glimpse of this contradiction. As Delhi prepared to host global leaders, roadside vendors were removed from prominent locations and informal settlements screened from public view. It exposed an uncomfortable truth: Delhi needs its informal economy, but often does not want its informal workers to be visible. Street vendors, construction workers, domestic workers, sanitation workers, small traders and delivery riders are essential to the Capital's functioning. Yet they are frequently treated as obstacles to a cleaner and more "planned" city.

Gig workers make this contradiction particularly clear. Delhi's platform economy increasingly depends on delivery riders who move through the city at all hours. Yet conventional planning rarely recognises them as an urban constituency. A delivery worker

needs safe parking, toilets, drinking water, charging points, rest spaces and affordable housing close to employment centres.

Housing presents a similar problem. The existence of housing in peripheral locations alongside informal housing closer to employment shows the limitations of a numbers-based approach. For a low-income household, housing cost includes rent, transport, commute time, childcare and access to work. A formally affordable house can be unaffordable if reaching work consumes hours

**Planning determines who gets access to housing, employment and public space, who benefits from rising land values and who bears the costs of development**

and a significant share of income.

Caste and occupation shape access to housing, land, dignity and public services. Workers in precarious occupations face insecurities that cannot be captured by income classifications alone. Likewise, women's inclusion cannot be achieved simply by adding toilets or childcare facilities. The location of affordable housing affects commuting, unpaid care work and access to employment. Housing, transport and care infrastructure must be planned together.

The same principle applies to persons with disabilities. A ramp is meaningless if the pavement leading to it is inaccessible or public transport cannot be reached independently. The test should be whether a person with a disability can independently travel from home to wherever necessary for work, education, healthcare and recreation.

Rehabilitation must also protect livelihoods. The principle of "*Jahan jhuggi, wahan makan*" is important, but relocation cannot simply mean moving residents to distant housing. It also raises the question of who captures the value created by public investment. New Metro lines and commercial corridors increase surrounding land values. If these gains accrue primarily to property owners while poorer residents are priced out, public investment risks producing private wealth while socialising displacement.

The real test of Delhi 2047 is not whether the capital becomes richer, taller or more connected. It is whether the people who build, clean, deliver, drive and sustain the city can still afford a place in its future.

*Khan is a Delhi-based architect*



# Supreme Court notice to Centre, Jharkhand govt on CBI probe plea over exam 'irregularities'

**Ananthakrishnan G**  
New Delhi, August 24

THE SUPREME Court Monday sought responses from the Centre and Jharkhand Government on a plea seeking an independent, time-bound CBI probe into alleged malpractices in the Jharkhand Combined Civil Services Preliminary Examination.

Appearing for petitioner and activist Harisharan Devgan, Senior Advocate Manan Kumar Mishra told a bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant that students had been protesting for more than a month seeking a probe by the Central Bureau of Investigation into the alleged irregularities.

Mishra told the bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, that the state had cancelled the examination, but the Jharkhand High Court stayed the decision. "The state also indi-

rectly supported," Mishra said.

The CJI said the court wants to know whether the judicial service exams are conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission or separately by the HC.

Mishra said the Commission conducted them, to which the CJI said, "We are worried about that". Mishra urged the SC to order a CBI investigation, preferably under the supervision of a former SC judge. The bench, however, indicated such an investigation would involve forensic examination of evidence and other technical aspects.

The petitioner said the plea did not seek cancellation of examination merely on the

basis of media reports or protests, "The principal relief sought is for an independent, impartial, comprehensive and time-bound investigation by the CBI, so that the nature, extent, mechanism and impact of the alleged irregularities may be objectively determined".

“Allegations require examination of the entire examination chain... generation of the result and publication thereof”.

The petitioner sought immediate preservation of physical and digital evidence, including original and candidate-held OMR copies, CCTV footage, and server audit logs, apprehending possible tampering.



‘INDIA IS WORKING TO OPEN THE DOORS TO INTERNATIONAL ENGAGEMENT’

# India, Japan to review trade pact, streamline investments: Official

**Sandeep Singh & Ravi Dutta Mishra**  
*Tokyo/New Delhi, August 24*

INDIA IS set to review its trade agreement with Japan signed in 2011 with an aim to fix the widening trade gap with the country and streamline committed investments worth 10 trillion yen (over \$62 billion) in the next 10 years, a government official said on Monday. This comes as a delegation of over 220 stakeholders from Indian industry, led by the Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal, is in Japan from 24th to 27th August to deepen collaboration with their Japanese counterparts.

Pitching for investment in India, Goyal at a roundtable here said that India is the fastest-growing large nation in the world and is poised to become a \$30 trillion economy by 2047. Bridging this gap is clearly on the agenda, and a roadmap has been laid out, Goyal said, adding that India is working to open the doors to international engagement.

“Today we have free trade agreements (FTAs) or preferential market access in markets

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worth \$17 trillion,” he said.

“I have three suggestions or asks, as I invite you to leverage the cost competitiveness of our FTAs and our engineering talent. I urge each one of you present in India and those who will be coming to deepen your localisation. It will help you become even more cost-competitive and actually help you supply your components to the rest of the world. The government is also willing to support you in innovation funding,” Goyal said.

Goyal cited the example of the first large investment by Suzuki Motor Corporation in the 1980s and said that the market cap of Suzuki in India is over 1.6 times that of the parent company Suzuki Motor Corporation. Stating that “some of the largest and most profitable operations are coming out of India,” the minister pointed to the journey of 1,580 Japanese companies in India, adding that “We would like to see 1,580 Suzukis being created out of India and the doubling of the number of the companies operating out of India.”

Piyush Goyal held several meetings during the day, includ-

## • TRADE RESET

**INDIA AIMS** to fix the widening trade gap with Japan and streamline committed investment worth 10 trillion yen (over \$62 billion) in the next 10 years

**INDIAN DELEGATION**, led by the Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, is in Japan from 24th to 27th August to deepen collaboration with their Japanese counterparts



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ing chairing a roundtable on capital goods, machinery, automotive and advanced manufacturing and engaging in talks with Keidanren (Japan Business Federation), Japan Chamber of Commerce & Industry. The Indian business delegation (over 200) met the Fintech Association of Japan and delegates from the Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency in Tokyo.

Responding to concerns over the use of safeguard measures raised by the Japanese companies during the round table, Goyal suggested the Japanese companies source steel from India rather than importing.

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Further, during the fireside chat with Nikkei Asia editor-in-chief Akito Tanaka, he said “We only use safeguards for the low end of the market, which is available in India. In any country, there will be certain areas where there are conflicting demands: local industries... foreign companies coming into the country, protecting certain sectors... sensitivities and because of that it could lead to a situation where in certain areas you may find it difficult to immediately get the attention of the policymakers...”

“But ours is a listening government; we have Invest India, which supports and handholds

## Meiji, Serum eye vaccine tie-up

*Tokyo/New Delhi:* Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal also discussed opportunities to strengthen India-Japan cooperation in the pharmaceutical sector and avenues to expand manufacturing and R&D with the President & Representative Director of Meiji Seika Pharma, Toshiaki Nagasato. The CEO, after the meeting, said that Meiji Seika Pharma is looking to partner with the Serum Institute of India for the supply of vaccines for Japanese Encephalitis. **ENS**

investors into India. The Commerce and Industry Ministry is working very actively to bring investment into the country and is always in the service of investors and business to help them in their journey in India and wherever possible we sort out the case,” Goyal said.

*Sandeep Singh is in Japan at the invitation of FICCI.*

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## PRIVATE AIRPORT SECTOR FACES OLIGOPOLY CONCERNS

# Centre plans to cap airports a bidder can win in next privatisation round

**ENS Economic Bureau**  
*New Delhi, August 24*

IN A bid to minimise risks related to market concentration and over-leveraging, the Ministry of Civil Aviation (MoCA) plans to cap the number of airport bundles that can be awarded to the same bidder in the upcoming round of airport privatisation, as per the ministry’s submission to Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPPAC) earlier this month.

The submission by MoCA was in response to a query from PPPAC Chair and Secretary, Department of Economic Affairs, Anuradha Thakur in an August 4 meeting on the planned privatisation of 11 airports — clubbed into five bundles — for a 50-year period. The panel gave its in-principle nod to the proposal, as per the minutes of the meeting.

Thakur had sought the ministry’s response on what

measures were envisaged to ensure that the risks related to concentration and over-leveraging are minimised, given the oligopolistic nature of the aviation sector. The PPPAC, under the Department of Economic Affairs, is responsible for appraisal and approval of central sector public private partnership (PPP) projects exceeding Rs 100 crore.

India’s private sector-operated airport ecosystem is dominated by two groups — Adani and GMR — and concerns over the sector’s oligopolistic nature have been flagged over the past few years. In the previous round of airport privatisation in 2019, the Adani Group walked away with all the six airports that were on offer. At present, the group operates eight airports — Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Jaipur, Lucknow, Guwahati, Thiruvananthapuram, Mangaluru, and Navi Mumbai. GMR operates six airports, including Delhi, Hyderabad, North Goa

(Mopa), Visakhapatnam, Nagpur, and Bidar.

“The number of airport bundles that may be awarded to a single bidder would be capped to mitigate the risks arising from market concentration and potential over-leveraging, including their possible cascading impact across projects. The modalities of such capping are being finalised and would be submitted as part of the proposal seeking final recommendation by the PPPAC,” MoCA said in response to Thakur’s query.

The airports planned to be offered in the next round of privatisation include Amritsar and Kangra-Gaggal (bundle 1), Raipur and Aurangabad (bundle 2), Bhubaneswar and Hubballi (bundle 3), Tiruchirappalli and Tiruparti (bundle 4), and Varanasi, Gaya and Kushinagar (bundle 5). All of these are currently under the Airports Authority of India.

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# Govt allows 4-month relief for clean energy projects amid West Asia crisis

**ENS Economic Bureau**  
*New Delhi, August 24*

THE CRISIS in West Asia is threatening to disrupt India’s renewable energy expansion momentum, with the government extending deadlines for projects scheduled to be commissioned on, or after the outbreak of war in the region.

In its latest advisory, the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) has asked renewable energy implementing agencies — including Solar Energy Corporation of India, NTPC Ltd, National Hydroelectric Power Corporation Ltd and SJVN Ltd, as well as the power,

energy and renewable energy departments of the state and Union Territory governments — to consider extensions of up to four months for projects scheduled to be commissioned on or after February 28, 2026. The move comes weeks after industry bodies sought relief from the ministry, warning that disruptions due to the conflict were affecting the procurement, manufacturing, logistics and execution of utility-scale renewable energy projects.

Meanwhile, government data also points to a slowdown in India’s pace of solar capacity addition in the latest quarter. In the April-June 2026 quarter,

solar capacity additions stood at 11.8 GW, down 18.1% from 14.4 GW in the previous quarter.

In FY26, the country added 44.61 GW of solar capacity, of which 16.3 GW, or 36%, came from distributed solar, leaving 28.31 GW from mainly utility-scale projects. In its advisory, MNRE referred to an April office memorandum issued by the Department of Expenditure under the Ministry of Finance, which clarified that the situation in West Asia should be treated as a “war” and provided for a time extension of up to four months on account of the crisis.

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# India is Claude’s second-largest market, but ranks 101st in per-capita usage

**Soumyarendra Barik**  
*New Delhi, August 24*

INDIA IS the second-largest market for Anthropic’s Claude AI by overall usage, but ranks near the bottom globally when that usage is adjusted for the size of its working-age population. The finding highlights how adoption of the chatbot remains limited to a relatively small section of users in the country — and India’s per-capita income may have a role to play.

According to Anthropic’s latest Economic Index, India ranks 101st among 116 countries in Claude usage per working-age person. The gap between India’s high aggregate usage

and its low per-capita ranking suggests that the country’s position as one of Claude’s biggest markets is driven largely by its population size, rather than widespread adoption of the AI tool across workers and consumers. “This gap suggests that India’s high Claude use overall reflects the sheer size of its population, not that the average person is using Claude heavily,” Anthropic said.

As of 2025, India’s per capita income is \$2,702 (Rs 2,58,548) per year. For reference, the per capita income of Bangladesh is \$2,597 while that of Sri Lanka is around \$5,000. The US has a per capita income of around \$90,000.

## Snapshot of India’s AI use

The findings point to a broader challenge for AI adoption in India, where access to and use of advanced AI tools remains uneven despite the country’s large technology workforce and the government’s push to expand domestic AI capabilities.

Anthropic’s analysis shows that higher-income countries generally record greater Claude usage per person, with factors such as income, access to digital infrastructure and awareness of AI tools likely influencing adoption.

“Globally, per-capita AI adoption is strongly correlated



On a regional basis, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, and Delhi together account for over half of India’s total Claude use. **REUTERS**

with per-capita income. India’s per-capita use is consistent with what this relationship would predict. Without ad-

ressing structural barriers related to income, digital infrastructure, and awareness outside the IT sector, Indian AI

adoption is likely to remain concentrated,” it added.

The data also suggests that Claude’s use in India is currently more closely linked to professional and technical work than broad-based consumer adoption.

This could limit the extent to which productivity gains from generative AI spread across sectors, particularly outside technology-heavy occupations and major economic centres.

It is worth noting that Anthropic’s analysis is based on Claude usage and may not be a measure of overall AI adoption in India, though it is one

of the most popular AI companies in the world.

## Indian states using Claude

Claude use in India is concentrated in a few economically high-performing states. Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, and Delhi together account for over half of India’s total Claude use — and “this pattern closely mirrors India’s IT sector geography and urban economic output,” the company said.

“The concentration in these four states — home to Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai, Mumbai, and Delhi NCR — sug-

gests that current AI adoption is driven primarily by India’s established technology workforce rather than broad-based consumer uptake,” it added.

The primary reasons that Indians are using Claude also reflect that gap. Anthropic said the occupational mix of Indian Claude AI use, inferred by mapping tasks to related occupations, skews towards software development and engineering roles, consistent with the country’s large IT services sector. “Broadening AI’s economic impact will require looking beyond software and IT services,” it added.

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COUNTRIES FACILITATING TEHRAN WILL BE CUT OFF FROM DOLLAR-BASED FINANCIAL SYSTEM: BESSENT

# US declares expansion of sanctions in its 'economic onslaught' on Iran

Treasury imposes sanctions on nearly 60 entities, vessels and individuals

David Lawder  
& Humeyra Pamuk  
Washington, August 24

THE US on Monday announced an expansion of secondary sanctions it hopes will "sever every economic lifeline" that sustains Iran, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said at a press conference.

Bessent unveiled what he described as an "economic D-Day" that aims to give a final warning to countries to cut their business ties with Iran or risk having key companies and entities cut off from the dollar-based financial system.

"We are launching an economic onslaught against Iran's financial connections around the globe. Our objective is to sever every economic lifeline that sustains this tyrannical re-



United States Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent speaks at a news conference on Monday. AP

gime until Tehran stands alone," Bessent said.

The US Treasury Department has mapped the networks, facilitators, and financial channels that Iran uses to smuggle oil and evade sanctions and said that Washington would be working with US partners to target any source of Iran's "illicit revenue."

The department said it has issued determinations against

five sectors — digital assets, technology, gold, aviation and shipping — that the Iranian government is using to prop up its economy. The Treasury has also imposed sanctions on nearly 60 entities, individuals and vessels.

China has for several years been the biggest buyer of Iranian oil and Washington has intensified its efforts to clamp down on Chinese purchases, but has so far stopped short of

designating larger Chinese banks that may be facilitating the oil trade.

Trump's war with Iran, which has pushed energy prices higher worldwide, is about to hit its six-month mark. While heavy fighting has subsided, diplomatic efforts to end the war have stalled and oil and raw material shipping through the Strait of Hormuz remains blocked, keeping energy prices elevated.

Trump's approval rating has fallen to a low point, with just 33% of Americans in the latest Reuters/Ipsos poll approving of his performance. He says the economic costs are necessary to ensure Iran does not have a nuclear weapon.

The US has maintained sanctions against Iran for decades, most of which have been aimed at curtailing the country's oil revenues, aviation sector, cryptocurrency, procurement of weapons components and other military hardware, and cutting off funding for business enterprises controlled by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, a dominant force in the Iranian economy. **REUTERS**

## Trump to codify rule imposing \$1,00,000 fee for H-1B work visa

Proposed rule would extend the fee imposed by Trump last year

Daniel Wiessner  
August 24

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump's administration on Monday released a proposed regulation to codify an unprecedented more than \$1,00,000 fee on new H-1B visas for highly skilled foreign workers that Trump first imposed last year but has been blocked by the courts.

The fee first imposed by Trump in a temporary proclamation last year vastly raises the cost of the visas that are heavily relied on in the tech, education and research sectors. A federal judge in June ruled that the fee was illegal and blocked the



The H-1B program offers 65,000 visas annually

Trump administration from collecting it.

A Boston-based appeals court is reviewing that decision while a different court considers whether a judge in Washington, DC, properly rejected a challenge to the fee by a major business group. Trump's 2025 proclamation imposing the fee expires in September, one year after it was issued, but directed the US Department of Homeland Security (DHS) to adopt regulations making it permanent.

The proposed \$103,265 fee by DHS, posted online in the Federal Register on Monday to be

formally published on Tuesday, kicks off a 30-day public comment period. The rule could be finalised by the end of the year.

The H-1B program allows US employers to hire foreign workers with training in specialty fields and offers 65,000 visas annually, with another 20,000 for workers with advanced degrees, approved for three to six years. The order Trump issued last year sharply increased the cost of obtaining some H-1B visas, which had typically come with about \$2,000 to \$5,000 in fees, depending on various factors.

Trump, a Republican, and other critics of the H-1B program say it is abused by many companies who replace American workers with cheaper foreign labor. But business groups and many individual companies have said the visa programme is needed to address a lack of qualified American workers for some jobs and to allow US businesses to recruit top talent. **REUTERS**

● RUSSIA AND UKRAINE TOGETHER ACCOUNT FOR NEARLY A THIRD OF THE WHEAT THAT THE WORLD BUYS; THIS YEAR, JUST AS HARVESTS BEGAN, THEIR GRAIN SHIPMENTS HAVE NEARLY GROUND TO A HALT

## World's breadbaskets are getting pounded by war, weather and trade spats

Somini Sengupta  
August 24

INSTANT NOODLES. Hot chapatis. Sliced bread.

Wheat is at the heart of the modern diet, and this year, it is facing an accumulation of modern dangers. The breadbaskets of the world are getting pummeled by drone strikes and devilish weather, nudging prices higher amid already soaring food costs in the wake of the Iran war.

Heat and drought have diminished harvests in some of the biggest wheat-producing countries, including the United States, which is expected to have its worst wheat harvest in a half-century, spiking prices. Low-income countries that agreed to buy American wheat under the threat of Trump tariffs could be

stuck paying abnormally high prices.

The Black Sea, a crucial passage for the global wheat trade, is an active theater of the Russia-Ukraine war, while the Houthis militia's attacks on shipping in the Red Sea have already forced grain shipments to take a longer, more expensive route around South Africa.

Beyond that, a supercharged El Nino further threatens water levels in the Panama Canal, while drought has reduced water levels to perilously low levels in transit routes like the Rhine and Danube rivers in Europe, raising transportation costs. All this at a time when the global atmosphere is hotter than normal because of a century of fossil fuel burning, threatening the livelihoods of small farmers in low-income countries.

The simultaneous troubles reveal the risks inherent in the global food system today. Only a few crops, like wheat, provide most of the world's calories. Relatively few governments dominate the export of wheat, including Russia, Canada, the United States, Ukraine and the European Union. Their customers are mainly low-income countries that no longer grow much of the food their people eat. "The system we currently have in place depends on three things: seamless trade, cheap energy, stable climate," said Evan Fraser, a professor who studies the global food system at the University of Guelph in Ontario. "Today, it seems none of these assumptions are met."

Few things are as politically potent as the price of bread, and wheat prices were already at a



Ukrainian soldiers patrol in an unharvested wheat field along frontline positions near Barvinkove. FILE/NYT

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three-year high in July, according to the Food and Agriculture Organization. The UN agency has warned of higher prices later this year.

The saving grace is that the world had a bumper harvest of

reinforce one another."

"A combination of El Nino-related weather impacts across major exporters, renewed constraints on Black Sea exports and further disruptions to key shipping routes would have implications far beyond wheat production itself," she said.

Russia and Ukraine together account for nearly a third of the wheat that the world buys. This year, just as harvests began, their grain shipments have nearly ground to a halt.

In recent weeks, Russia and Ukraine have stepped up their attacks on each other's grain export terminals and ships in the Black Sea, a waterway they share to get their goods out to the world.

Wildfires this summer spared the wheat belt of France, the EU's largest wheat producer.

But the heat has not.

France expects lower yields because of record heat this summer, according to government projections. Germany's main farmers group said Tuesday that yields were down for several crops, including wheat, because of drought and heat. In July, the European trade group for agricultural commodities, Cereal, issued a special bulletin, estimating lower grain yields of 286.6 million metric tons this year, compared with 310 million metric tons in 2025, for the Continent and for Britain.

Australia, also a major wheat exporter, planted fewer acres of wheat because of high fertiliser costs, stemming from the Strait of Hormuz closure.

The United States is about to have its worst wheat harvest since 1970, largely because of a

terrible drought in the Great Plains, the US Department of Agriculture estimated in its latest report this month. American farmers had devoted fewer acres to wheat, and yields per acre were also down.

Rising prices of imported wheat put enormous pressure on governments that are forced to buy high and then help subsidise the costs to keep bread prices within the reach of its people.

Egypt, which buys most of its wheat from abroad, including from Russia and Ukraine, has tried to bolster wheat production at home, with the government offering higher prices to farmers. Still, Egypt remains far from reaching anything close to self-sufficiency. There is simply not enough water to produce what the country needs. **NYT**



• ECONOMICS

# The other ‘NEET’ that India needs to address



UDIT MISRA

YOUTH PROTESTS that forced the resignation of India’s Union Education Minister almost exactly a month ago have not only brought the issue of education into sharp focus, but also highlighted concerns related to unemployment — especially among the youth.

Until now, the government has often cited data on the Unemployment Rate (UER) to suggest that Indians are doing well on the jobs front. The UER is calculated as the number of unemployed people within the total labour force (those currently working or looking for work). Official data from the Periodic Labour Force Surveys (PLFS) says that the UER has fallen steadily from 6.1% in 2017-18 — hitting a 45-year high — to just 3.1% in 2025.

This is the UER for those aged 15 years and above, suggesting that broadly, the Indian economy has been creating jobs. However, at least three immediate problems arise even if one looks only at the UER.

## Youth unemployment: Growing worry

The first problem is that the UER for those between the ages of 15 and 29 years is still quite high, even though this number has also been falling. It has fallen from almost 18% in 2017-18 to around 10% in 2022-23 but has since stayed at this level.

In fact, not only is the unemployment rate highest among the youth as a cohort, it rises with educational attainment. As *Chart 1* shows, graduates aged 25 face the highest unemployment rate — as high as almost 40%. It means that on average, 4 out of 10 graduates aged 25 years looking for work fail to get it.

The data is from the State of Working India (SWI) 2026 report by researchers at the Azim Premji University. They also calculated that the UER among young Indians with education up to graduation or more was actually higher in 2023 than in 1983.

While graduates being unemployed is not a new phenomenon in India, so much so that even movies of yesteryears capture this routine but crushing reality, the situation

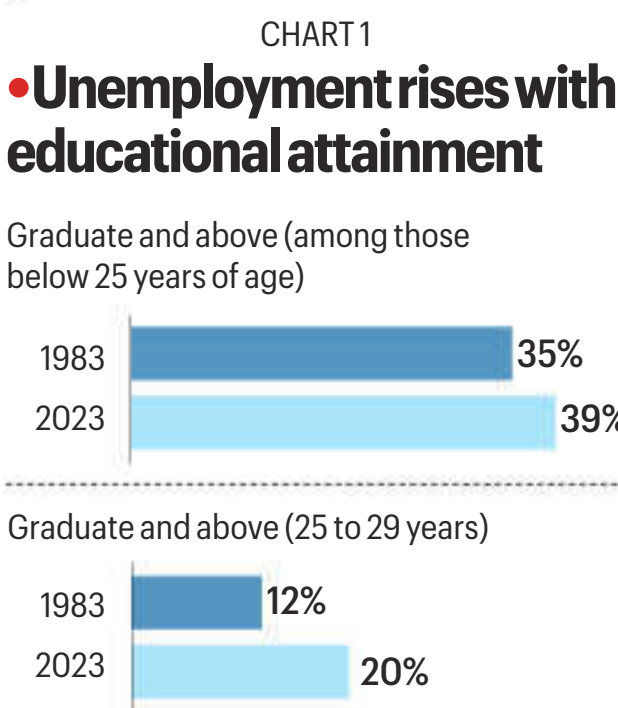
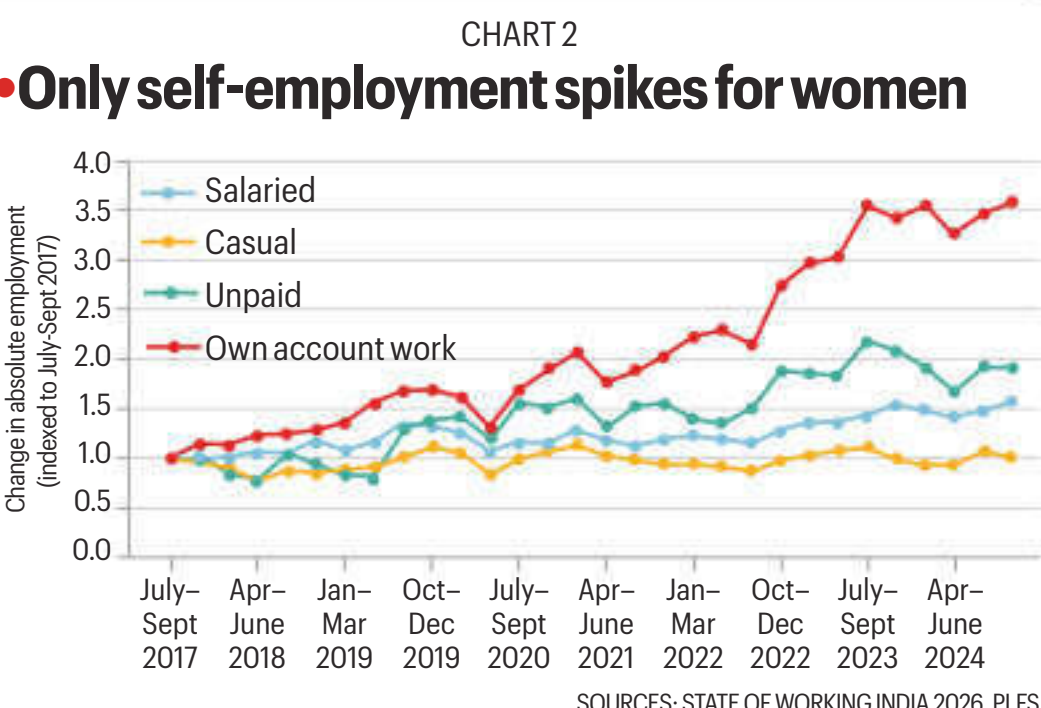


TABLE 1

• Size of workforce (in millions)

| Year           | Male | Female | Total |
|----------------|------|--------|-------|
| 2017-18        | 338  | 94     | 433   |
| 2018-19        | 343  | 97     | 440   |
| 2019-20        | 357  | 122    | 480   |
| 2020-21        | 357  | 126    | 483   |
| 2021-22        | 363  | 126    | 490   |
| 2022-23        | 349  | 128    | 477   |
| 2023-24        | 387  | 186    | 573   |
| 2025 (Jan-Dec) | 416  | 206    | 616   |



SOURCES: STATE OF WORKING INDIA 2026, PLFS

seems to be worsening over time.

## Quality of jobs, not just quantity

The second problem is that while more jobs have been created since 2017-18, there is a big question mark on their quality. *Table 1* shows the size of the Indian workforce — the total number of people with a job. It has risen from 43.3 crore (or 433 million) in 2017-18 to around 61 crore as of December 2025.

But a closer look shows that most new jobs are either in agriculture or in pursuits that pay little or see stagnant earnings. The SWI 2026 pointed out: “In the post-Covid period India’s employed population has increased... with employment rates rising from 71 to 74 percent for men and from 26 to 34 percent for women, between 2021-22 and 2023-24. But the majority of employment creation has been in agriculture. Of the 83 million jobs added between 2021-22 and 2023-24, 40 million have been in agriculture, with women accounting for a large share (38 million).”

Similarly, while women have increasingly joined India’s workforce — from 94 million in 2017-18 to 186 million in 2023-24 — as *Chart 2* shows, most earn very little. “The number of women in own-account self-employment has seen a nearly four-fold increase since 2017. Self-employment earnings among women and salaried earnings (for men and women) have largely stagnated,” states the report.

## Unemployment rate misleads

Lastly, in a developing economy such as India, using the UER to assess job market stress can be deeply misleading. That’s be-

## Capturing lack of jobs

In India, there is evidence to show that not everyone registers in official surveys as people looking for a job.

• NEET, an acronym for ‘Not in Employment, Education, or Training’, is a metric that can help measure unemployment in a more comprehensive manner.

cause the unemployment rate is measured as a percentage of the people demanding a job. While this is a reasonable approach generally, in India, evidence shows that not everyone registers in official surveys as people looking for a job. As such, the number of people unemployed is often far more than what is captured.

Rosa Abraham, an associate professor of economics who teaches at APU and is one of the authors of the SWI report, told *The Indian Express*, “Unemployment is only measured when you are willing to work and/or searching for a job. But, especially in the case of women (in India), what would happen is that regardless of their education, and even when they have, say, completed graduation, they may not explicitly record or be recorded (in the surveys) as looking for work.” Such women thus get counted out of the “labour force”.

If these people were counted as unemployed, they would then be part of the labour force, and the unemployment rate would be much higher.

“So UER is really the lowest estimate of people who are not being mobilised into the workforce. There is an entire pool of people who are out of the labour force who are either discouraged workers, or there are social norms (often for women) that keep them out of work,” explains Abraham.

## The other NEET

Another metric better captures how the Indian economy is failing its youth. It is called NEET — an acronym for “Not in

Employment, Education, or Training”.

NEET “is a comprehensive measure of this labour under-utilisation while excluding those in education or training. NEET not only includes the unemployed, but also those who are of working age and are neither in education/training nor employment,” the APU report says.

Simply put, NEET presumes that many people may be pursuing education and, as such, they cannot be expected to join the workforce. So, NEET attempts to understand the share of people outside this umbrella.

According to PLFS data from March, 25% of Indian youth were NEET. Population projections by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare state that India’s youth population in 2026 stood at 36.8 crore, making it the world’s largest youth population. If one applies the same proportion of NEET to 2026, out of a total youth population of 368 million (36.8 crore), around 92 million or 9.2 crore are in NEET.

In other words, the number of Indian youth neither involved in education nor skilling nor any kind of employment today is around 9.2 crore — almost equal to the entire population of Iran.

Apart from the high youth unemployment rate, such a high absolute number of NEET population may explain the growing youth unrest in the country. It is also important to remember that these numbers are at a time when the government is happy with the pace of economic growth based on GDP figures, even calling it a “goldilocks” period.

• HISTORY

# Tracing Ashoka in Ujjain: What new dig at Vaishya Tekri can reveal

Nikita Mohta

New Delhi, August 24

THE MADHYA Pradesh government has begun restoring Buddhist monuments linked to the Mauryan emperor Ashoka, starting with a fresh excavation at Vaishya Tekri in Ujjain.

Initial excavations by the Department of Archaeology of the erstwhile Gwalior State in 1938–39 unveiled large bricks and punch-marked coins here, prompting archaeologists to date the structure to the Mauryan period.

In his 2011 paper, “Asoka and Buddhist Nuns: Early Buddhism in Ujjain and Malwa”, academic Peter Skilling wrote: “The largest stupa, popularly called Vaisya Tekri, is about 350 feet at its base and 100 feet high. Nearby is a smaller stupa, called Kumbhar (or Kumhar) Tekri. Both are relatively undisturbed, except for the unfortunate fact that a power line runs between them, and a giant pylon squats rudely on Kumbhar Tekri’s shoulder.”

But academic Himanshu Prabha Ray, in an interview with *The Indian Express*, urged caution, noting that the excavation report is decades old and that its interpre-

tation was shaped by earlier accounts, particularly Alexander Cunningham’s writings on Ashoka. While acknowledging the mound’s impressive size and its reported comparison with the Great Stupa at Sanchi, Ray said, “I think we are jumping the gun. We need to investigate further beyond the 1938-39 excavation.”

## Ashoka’s years in Ujjain

Ujjayini (modern Ujjain), on the banks of the Sipra, a tributary of the Chambal, was the capital of Avanti and an important commercial centre. Historian Romila Thapar, in *Asoka and the Decline of the Mauryas*, notes that Ujjain was a major crossroads, linking trade routes to western coastal ports such as Broach and Sopira, as well as to Pataliputra.

Ashoka was sent to Avanti as viceroy by his father, Bindusara. Unlike his brief sojourn in Taxila, he is believed to have spent about a decade in Avanti, with Ujjain as his headquarters. Thapar writes, “We feel that he was sent to Taxila for a special purpose and after having completed his work there, he was then appointed to the viceroyalty at Ujjain in recognition of his work.”

## Ancient city

• Mud fortifications were first built around Ujjain in the seventh century BCE. By about the sixth century BCE, Avanti, with Ujjain as its capital, had emerged as a powerful independent kingdom.

• Historian Nayanjot Lahiri says of Ujjain, “By the time Ashoka got there, it was an urban centre of respectable antiquity, having flourished along the Sipra river for 300 years or more before it became his place of functioning.”



Vaishya Tekri has an estimated height of 100 ft, against the 54 ft Sanchi Stupa. EXPRESS Real Creator IAS Edition [https://t.me/+2RvD\\_RGf9mljMzg1](https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1) Where Ashoka met Devi

On his way to Ujjain, Ashoka stopped in Vidisha, where he met Vedisadevi, the daughter of a merchant. They later had a son, Mahinda, and a daughter, Sanghamitta.

Ashoka’s appointment to Ujjain appears to be well supported by historical evidence: his own edicts, issued after he became emperor, refer to the presence of a prince, or kumara, at Ujjain.

Lahiri also points to the geography, “Ashoka is shown as meeting Devi at Vidisha, and Vidisha falls on the way to Ujjayini from Pataliputra”.

## Fresh excavations

Scholars have welcomed the government’s decision to fund excavations.

Ray points to Sanchi, where the ashes of Buddhist teachers who taught or stayed at its monasteries were buried around stupas. “The stupa does not occur as an isolated structure. It always has smaller stupas and other structures around it. I would suggest that the excavations look beyond the stupa itself and use the money to understand how the site grew over time: what other structures were around it, and who were the monks who taught or stayed there.”

• INFRASTRUCTURE

# Inside Andhra’s policy to enforce ‘right to walk’

Dheeraj Mishra

New Delhi, August 24

IN INDIA, one in every five persons killed in a road accident is a pedestrian. After the Supreme Court’s order recognising the right to walk on footpaths as a fundamental right earlier this year, Andhra Pradesh has become the country’s first state to formulate a pedestrian safety policy.

The Andhra Pradesh Pedestrian Safety and Universal Accessibility Policy 2026, notified on August 7, mandates a three-step system: road safety audits, fixing footpath infrastructure (including removal of encroachments) and behavioural change.

The policy will apply to all local body areas. Agencies responsible for roads in cities with populations above one million have been directed to implement it first.

The policy also invokes Section 198A of the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, under which officials, contractors, and consultants can be fined Rs 1 lakh if infrastructural or design failures cause pedestrian death or disability.

## Footpath audits

Local authorities will conduct an audit of the existing footpaths with priority to crowded and high-footfall areas such as markets, railway stations, bus stands, religious and educational institutions. It says authorities must prioritise at least 15-20 specific “black spots” — places where there have been frequent pedestrian injuries or deaths in the last 2-3 years.

The audit will cover the assessment of the physical condition of the pavement and pedestrian crossings. The authorities must survey 20% of roads within one year of policy commencement to assess additional pedestrian crossing requirements, and finalise the work within seven months.

The policy directs the mandatory removal of unauthorised structures, illegal stalls and other encroachments on footpaths. But it does not specify any timeline for this. It recommends automated and camera-based monitoring systems for these footpaths, and deployment of pedestrian guardrails and bollards.

## • PEDESTRIAN DEATHS

• In 2024, out of 8,346 road accident deaths in Andhra Pradesh, 1,739 were pedestrians. Of 1.77 lakh road deaths recorded in 2024 across India, 36,526 were pedestrians.

• Around 31% of pedestrian deaths occur on national highways alone.

## Specifications of footpath

The footpaths shall have a minimum walking area of two metres to accommodate wheelchairs comfortably, 0.4-1 metre of buffer space and a 1.5-metre area for multi-utility zone to accommodate tree pits, auto rickshaw stands,

seating and on-street vending.

The height shall not be more than 150 mm from the road. The surface must be firm, stable, even and slip-resistant. The bollards to prevent bikes from entering the footpath should be 0.5-0.7 metres high with a clear spacing of 0.6 metres between them, and one with 1 metre width for wheelchair access.

The pedestrian policy also mandates the tactile pavers to aid visually impaired persons and curb ramps at all crossings. It discourages forcing pedestrians onto inaccessible foot overbridges where at-grade crossings like zebra crossing can be safely provided.

## Social policing and performance

The policy has also included the provision of behavioural change among citizens. A district-level grievance mobile application or portal will be created to facilitate the reporting of violations by citizens. It also mandates the ranking metric for evaluating the performance of different urban local bodies on pedestrian safety.

• CLIMATE

# Why Indian cities flood after heavy rain and overheat in summer every year



EXPERTS EXPLAIN  
AMAN KUMAR & SALONI SRIVASTAVA

RESEARCHERS AT GATEWAY RESEARCH (IGSD INDIA), NEW DELHI

FROM INTENSE heat across Delhi-NCR in May to heavy rain inundating the city’s arterial roads and low-lying sectors on Monday, both extreme weather events exposed the same problem. Weather translates into an urban disaster when it is met with dense construction, weak drainage, loss of open land, unsafe housing and public systems that aren’t ready for those most at risk.

## When does a natural hazard become an urban disaster?

A heatwave, cloudburst or cyclone is a hazard, but it becomes a disaster when it strikes a place where people, buildings, and public services are exposed and lack the capacity to withstand it.

Heavy rain need not cause severe flooding in a city if water can drain, spread or seep into the ground. But the same rain can bring it to a halt when natural drains have been narrowed, lakes and floodplains built over, and large areas covered with concrete.

The same applies to heat. Dense construction, asphalt, poor ventilation and the loss of tree cover cause neighbourhoods to absorb heat during the day and retain it after sunset.

The danger is greater for people living in poorly ventilated homes and for those who work outdoors without reliable access to shade, drinking water or healthcare.

The hazard may begin with the weather, but the extent of the damage depends on how the city has been built and governed.

## Why are Indian cities becoming more vulnerable?

Heatwaves and periods of intense rainfall are becoming more severe, while cities continue to replace soil, vegetation and water bodies with buildings, roads and other hard surfaces. This raises local temperatures and leaves less ground through which rainwater can drain. The World Bank estimates that temperatures in Indian city centres can be 3-4°C higher than in surrounding areas.

India’s urban population is expected to reach 951 million by 2050, and more than half the infrastructure that Indian cities will need by then is yet to be built. Whether this adds to the risk will depend on where construction is permitted, what materials are used, and whether natural drainage systems and open spaces are retained.

## What do these disasters cost?

Official estimates generally capture deaths and damage to roads, buildings and other public assets. They are less likely to capture wages lost by informal workers, the

cost of illness, the disruption of small businesses or the time spent recovering from repeated flooding.

In terms of avoidable losses, the World Bank estimates that timely adaptation could prevent annual urban flood losses of about \$5 billion by 2030 and \$30 billion by 2070. Measures to reduce extreme heat could also save more than 130,000 lives by 2050.

## What has changed in the law?

After a 2025 amendment, Section 41A of The Disaster Management Act, 2005, allows state governments to constitute an Urban Disaster Management Authority in every state capital and city with a municipal corporation, except Delhi and Chandigarh. These authorities are responsible for preparing and implementing an urban disaster management plan.

A separate change was made to disaster financing in August 2026, when heatwaves and lightning were included in the list of notified natural calamities. States can now use disaster response funds for eligible relief,

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Vn2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> while heatwave mitigation projects can receive support from disaster mitigation funds.

## Where does the system fall short?

The amendment leaves the constitution of urban disaster authorities to state governments and sets no deadline. Except Bengaluru, responsibility in most cities remains divided among municipal corporations, district administrations and state departments, which may work under different plans and lines of authority.

There is also a shortage of basic planning capacity. A 2021 NITI Aayog report found that 65% of India’s 7933 urban settlements had no master plan. State planning departments were either understaffed or had posts lying vacant.

## What would reduce the risk?

Disaster planning needs to become part of the routine decisions through which a city grows. Flood maps should determine where construction is prohibited, where drainage capacity must be increased and

what plinth levels buildings must maintain. Heat maps should inform requirements for shade, ventilation, tree cover and building materials.

City governments need qualified urban planners and technical experts working on development decisions, so that plans account for hazards and appropriate resilience measures. Urban investment decisions and project approvals should then follow the plans these teams prepare, with responsibility assigned for each measure and deadlines that can be reviewed before the next expected disaster.

Financing must extend beyond relief after an event. Early warnings should also trigger measures agreed in advance, including changes in outdoor working hours, hospital preparedness, school closures and traffic diversions.

Weather risk cannot be removed from a city. But when the same roads flood and the same neighbourhoods overheat each year, the failure lies in decisions that were made well before the season began.